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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

INSTRUCTION ISSUED FOR EXPEDITING INTER-MINISTERIAL COORDINATION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed that the files presented in various thematic ministries for opinions should be returned to the concerned bodies within 15 days with needed feedback.

The Prime Minister directed the ministries on Thursday to improve inter-ministerial coordination and expedite the decision-making process.

According to the instruction, if any ministry fails to return files to the concerned bodies within 15 days, it will automatically be regarded that they have been approved.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on January 9 took this decision in accordance with Good Governance Act as many development works, formulation of laws and services were affected as the ministries delayed in approving or giving feedback even after receiving files. He also instructed all ministries to follow it.

Prime Ministers' press advisor Govinda Acharya said, "Now it will be clear whether the work is going to be done or not. No one will be allowed to delay the process in approving or rejecting the received files."

MAN HELD FOR DUPING OVER 600 FOREIGN JOB ASPIRANTS

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 1

The Valley Investigation Office, Kathmandu has arrested a person for duping more than 600 foreign job aspirants. The 32-year-old fraudster was made public by the police on Thursday.

Bikash Tamang (Waiba), 32, from Kanjosom rural municipality-4 of Lalitpur was arrested from Lele, Lalitpur. He had duped hundreds of people-lured them of sending foreign countries and providing jobs.

» SEE PAGE 6

Today's Supplement Highlight

Japan: Blend of tradition and innovation

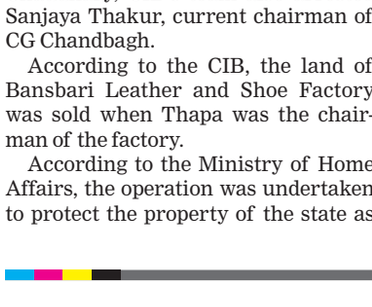




PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressing the 7th assembly of Rajarshi Janak University in Kathmandu on Thursday.

No proposal made to stop public welfare ads: Minister Sharma

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has clarified that no proposal has been made to stop public welfare advertisement.

Minister Sharma said that old laws related to the media sector have been amended, and consolidated and necessary new laws will be made in the mass media sector.

Minister Sharma, who is also the government spokesperson, made it clear that the Ministry has not proposed to stop public welfare advertisement being currently distributed to several media.

For amending laws and creating new ones, a committee consisting of experts has been formed to draft various laws based on the reports of the committee headed by Dr. Suresh Acharya, former president of FNJ and senior journalist.

Former FNJ President Dr. Mahendra Bista, Govinda Acharya, Babita Basnet and President of the Federation of Nepali Journalists Bipul Pokhrel were members of the Mass Communication Improvement Suggestion Committee.

Taking the report of the committee as the main basis, the work of lawmaking in the field of mass communication is now being carried out, Minister Sharma said.

Based upon the report of the committee formed to make improvements in the mass communication sector led by Dr. Acharya, the government will hold discussions among the stakeholders, take public opinions and suggestions from the website, and based on those suggestions, a draft will be prepared and other related ministries will be consulted, Minister Sharma said.



Minister Sharma said that old laws related to the media sector have been amended, and consolidated and necessary new laws will be made in the mass media sector.

"There is no truth in the news published in some media, and I urge all the media to study mass communication bill thoroughly and make necessary suggestions," Minister Sharma urged.

Accordingly, feedbacks have been received on Nepal Media Council Bill from the Ministry of Finance and it has been sent to the Ministry of Law for further opinion, while the mass communication bill has been sent to the Ministry of Finance for opinion, Minister Sharma clarified.

Particularly, according to the content of the Mass Media Policy-2073 B.S., establishment of the Mass Media Authority has been envisioned as a new structure to re-organise the mass media sector, while the Media Council has been deemed as a real regulatory body, it was said in the attention paper issued by the Ministry on Thursday.

In the proposed Media Council Bill, focusing on the code of conduct, the right to issue journalist ID card is included, while the classification of newspapers (now called media because online media also have to be classified) previously done by the Press Council, has been incorporated in the Mass Media Bill.

Based on the same classification, the provision of public welfare advertisement to be received by the media has already been clarified in the advertisement act and regulations.

"Ignoring this fact and overshadowing the making of the mass media sector law, it is reported that the government has proposed a law to stop public welfare advertisement, but there is no truth in the news published in some media, and I urge all to study the Mass Communication Bill in full and make necessary suggestions," read the statement.

In the Section 38 of the Mass Communication Bill, classification of mass communication institutions has been proposed.

Brain drain should be stopped: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the alarming situation of brain drain from the country should be stopped.

Speaking at the 7th assembly of Rajarshi Janak University on Thursday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that intellectuals could be nourished through full utilisation of the University's dedication, capacity and creative initiative.

Stating that every graduate of Rajarshi Janak University carried the present picture and the future of education in the country, the Prime Minister emphasized that the education system should be reformed accordingly. He stressed the need to develop capable human resource to lead the country.

Prime Minister Prachanda said universities should improve policies, curriculum and teaching process as the education sector was highly affected by globalisation. He said, "Competitive education based on innovation should be emphasized."

The Prime Minister also lauded the University for conducting undergraduate and postgraduate academic programmes in the fields of medical education, management and computer technology in a short period of its establishment.

He also assured that the difficulties faced by the University due to the lack of land and building infrastructure would be addressed gradually with the improvement of the economy. He said that the government would assist in the policies and management of academic programmes.

Study team formed to operate int'l airports under PPP model

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

The government has formed a study committee regarding the operation of the international airports in public private partnership (PPP) model.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on Thursday approved the proposal to form a study committee submitted by the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation.

CABINET DECISIONS

As per the decision, a five-member committee has been formed under the coordination of former secretary Shankar Prasad Adhikari, investment expert Ghana Shyam Ojha, Buddhi Sagar Lamichhane, head of the aviation division of the Ministry, Dipendra Shrestha, Joint Secretary of the Investment Board and Deputy Director of the Civil Aviation Authority, as member secretary, according to Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma.

The committee has been formed to study the issue of operating Tribhuvan International Airport in Kathmandu, Gautam Buddha International Airport in Bhairahawa and Pokhara International Airport in Pokhara at full capacity under PPP model.

Similarly, the government has formed a committee to take the national flag carrier Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) into a management contract. The committee was formed under the chairmanship of former governor and former member of the National Planning Commission, Deependra Bahadur Kshetry.

According to the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, the Kshetry-committee was formed for the operation of the Corporation under management contract.

The committee has Tika Ram Rai as a management expert, while other members include Chakra Bahadur Budha, Director General of Tourism Department, Joint Secretary of the Ministry of Finance, who is a member of NAC's Board of Directors, and Head of Finance Department of the Corporation.

The committee has been given a period of 45 days to decide the modality of awarding the management contract.

Kshetry and Rai were also in another committee formed earlier to enhance the managerial efficiency of the Corporation. This committee has already given its report.

Likewise, Bikram Rai has been appointed as the Vice Chairman of Nepal Airlines Corporation. Earlier to this, Bikram Rai was the member of the board of directors of the NAC.

Bikram Rai has been appointed to the post in accordance with Sub-section 4 of the Section 4 of the Nepal Airlines Service Act-2019 B.S.

Similarly, the Cabinet meeting decided to endorse and table a Bill prepared to amend the Safe Transactions Act-2063 B.S. in the Federal Parliament.

Spokesperson of the government and Minister Sharma said that the meeting has nominated Lekh Nath Lama of Sindhupalchowk and Dr. Sahara Shrestha of Kathmandu as members of the Naradevi Ayurveda Hospital Development Board on the proposal of the Ministry of Health and Population. Also, the Cabinet meeting appointed Uma Shanker Prasad of Rautahat as member of the National Planning Commission.

The Cabinet meeting has decided that the Nepali Army should immediately provide land for the expansion of Bharatpur Airport in Chitwan and the Civil Aviation Authority will build the broken structure of the Army, provide land to the Nepali Army in Shaktikhor for horse breeding centre and the government will bear the necessary expenses.

Three, including Arun Chaudhary, held on land grab case

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

The Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) arrested Arun Chaudhary, managing director of CG Holdings, from Lazimpat on Thursday. Chaudhary was arrested on the charge of unlawfully converting 10 ropanis land of Bansbari Leather and Shoe Factory into private property.

Along with Chaudhary, the CIB arrested the then chairman of Bansbari Leather Shoe Factory, Ajit Narayan Singh Thapa, on the charge of transferring the factory's land into the name of an individual.

Thapa was arrested from Battisputali in Kathmandu for investigation in the case of CG Residency Pvt. Ltd. Following the arrest of Thapa and Chaudhary, CIB's team also arrested Sanjaya Thakur, current chairman of CG Chandbagh.

According to the CIB, the land of Bansbari Leather and Shoe Factory was sold when Thapa was the chairman of the factory.

According to the Ministry of Home Affairs, the operation was undertaken to protect the property of the state as part of the Home Minister's good governance campaign.

Along with Chaudhary, the CIB arrested the then chairman of Bansbari Leather Shoe Factory, Ajit Narayan Singh Thapa, on the charge of transferring the factory's land into the name of an individual.

Meanwhile, the Kathmandu District Court has allowed Nepal Police to put Chaudhary and Thapa in a four-day remand in the case.

According to Superintendent of Police (SP) and Spokesperson for the Central Investigation Bureau of Nepal Police, Nava Raj Adhikari, the Court has given four-day remand order to conduct necessary investigation against Chaudhary and Singh Thapa.

A single bench of Judge Madhav Prasad Ghimire of the Court has permitted to be detained for four days for investigation.

Western Nepal witnesses rain, snowfall

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

Four of the seven provinces across the country including Kathmandu Valley received the first rainfall of this winter season since Wednesday evening. Some high mountainous areas of Karnali and Koshi received snowfall.

After the light rainfall, residents in Kathmandu were seen making fires on the roadside to keep themselves warm.

With the onset of rainfall, farmers are delighted as they have been eagerly waiting for winter rain to nourish their land for winter crops. However, on the flip side, earthquake victims in and around Jajarkot are enduring hardship due to the cold and rain, with some of them residing under the open sky.

According to Ganga Nagarkoti, a senior meteorologist at the Meteorological Forecasting Division under the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology (DHM), despite the western part of the country receiving light to moderate rainfall along with snow in the mountainous areas, the western disturbance failed to bring good moisture to the central and eastern parts.

The present weather condition will improve across the country from Friday morning, she added.



PHOTO: TRN

Snowfall in Bajura district.

According to DHM, there has been light to moderate precipitation in numerous locations in Sudurpashchim Province, several parts in Karnali Province, and one or two spots in Lumbini Province. Additionally, isolated showers have been noted in certain areas of the central and eastern Tarai regions of the country.

In the Kathmandu Valley, a few areas are expected to experience very light rainfall, while clouds and haze have covered the sky throughout the day. However, this situation is expected to improve starting from Friday, she added.

Meanwhile, Sher Bahadur Sarki, a correspondent from Bajura, reported that districts including Bajhang, Jumla, and Bajura experienced the first rainfall of the season, accompanied by snowfall in the mountainous regions.

Areas such as Budhinanda, Himali, Jagannath, Swakikartik, and others are currently experiencing rainfall along with snowfall. Additionally, Badimalika, Triveni, and Khaptad Chhededaha Rural Municipalities have been receiving snowfall since Thursday.

With the rising cold, the number of people suffering from pneumonia, colds, and coughs has increased, particularly affecting children and senior citizens.

Farmers are relieved and happy about the recent snowfall in their district. The rain and snow came just in time to save their winter wheat and barley crops from drying up, they said.

Kabita Sarki from Triveni Municipality-8 said that this timely precipitation made farming much easier. In Bajura, most areas rely on rainwater for cultivation, and snowfall helps control pests like grasshoppers.

Similarly, Sailendra Rokaya, a correspondent from Bajhang, reported that high Himalayan areas like Saipal, Surma and Dahabagar, have received snowfall, while lower regions experienced normal rainfall.

This precipitation has brought relief to farmers who rely on rain for their non-irrigated crops. Khadak Kathayat, a local, mentioned that crops were on the brink of failure due to prolonged drought but this rainfall with snowfall brought relief to farmers in the region.

Similarly, Netra Shahi, correspondent from Jumla reported that Jumla experienced snowfall, notably in the high Himalayan area, relieving farmers who were waiting for rainfall and snowfall for their winter crops.

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Bring cargo trains through Biratnagar Customs Yard, NITDB urges traders

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

The Nepal Intermodal Transport Development Board (NITDB) has urged the private sector businesses and traders to bring cargo trains through the Biratnagar Customs Yard.

The (NITDB), Customs Office and Railway Company said they were ready to facilitate the private sector traders while conducting international trade through the Yard.

During the India visit of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' from May 31 to June 3 last year, he and Indian PM Narendra Modi jointly inaugurated the train service. Subsequently, the first train with cargo arrived at the Nepal Customs Yard in Budhnagar of Biratnagar from Bathnaha, India on June 1.

Since that day, NITDB, Customs Office and Railway Company have been ready to welcome cargo trains. However, the Yard is not getting enough business.

Issuing a statement on Thursday, the NITDB said that it has repeatedly discussed the operation of the Yard with business people and is requesting to bring cargo through rail.

There will not be any hassles if any trader wants to bring in cargo through the Yard, said Executive Director of the Board, Ashish Gajurel.



Meanwhile, a discussion was held between the NITDB and the Managing Director of the Railway Company, Niranjan Jha in Kathmandu.

During the discussion, it was decided to immediately deploy contact persons from NITDB and the company at the newly developed Yard. It was also decided that both sides were ready for cargo management and requested businessmen to bring cargo trains.

All preparations have been completed to manage the cargo brought by the traders at the minimum fee set by the Government of Nepal.

"Security has also been well arranged, if there are any problems, they will be properly managed," said Gajurel. The dry ports and Integrated Check Posts (ICPs) in Nepal are modern, and equipped with necessary machines, tools, and human resources, claimed the Board.

Export business must form backbone of economy: FM Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has pointed out the need to develop export business as the backbone of the country's economy.

Dr. Mahat made this remark while addressing the establishment day and fourth anniversary of Federation of Export Entrepreneurs' Nepal (FEEN) on Wednesday evening.

He said that the role played by exporters in promoting economic growth, job creation, revenue growth, and sustainable development of the country was important.

"With the dedication and hard work of all our exporters, it has been contributing significantly to increasing the market demand for Nepali products in the global market and expanding our export capacity," he said.

He said the demands raised by the FEEN are genuine, but the government will not be able to address them immediately due to the lack of financial resources in the country.

He expressed his commitment to provide additional concessions to the exporters in the near future for enhancing export capacity of the exporters by making competitive Nepali products in the global market.

Similarly, he made it clear that there is no need to raise the issue of South Asia Free Trade Area (SAFTA) without benefiting from the trade agreement with India.

Stating that the future of the export sector is very good, he said that the government would continue its efforts to create an environment for an export-oriented economy.

Dr. Mahat emphasised that Nepali products should be original rather than high-tech ones.

FEEN President Shankar Pandey said that the government should play a significant role in marketing Nepali products in the international arena.

He said that the government's support was a must to increase exports as the private sector alone cannot promote goods and services in the international market.

On the occasion, Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, Member of Parliament Ganesh Parajuli, President of Federation of Nepal Chamber of Commerce and Industry Chandra Prasad Dhakal, President of Nepal Chamber of Commerce Rajendra Malla, Secretary of the Ministry of Commerce and Supplies Narayan Prasad Sharma Dawadee and Secretary of National Planning Commission Toya Narayan Gyawali, among others, were present.

On the occasion, the FEEN honoured the best exporters recognising their contribution for prompting export and bringing foreign currency in the country.



PHOTO: TRN
Finance Minister Dr Prakash Sharan Mahat.

Connect citizens with production: CM Pandey

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Feb. 1

The Chief Minister of Gandaki Province, Surendra Raj Pandey, has said that the economy will be sustainable only if citizens can be connected to production. Saying that the economy has not been sustainable lately, he stated that there would be no economic sustainability until there were more productive activities.

While inaugurating the 8th Walling Festival that kicked off on Thursday in Walling of Syangja district, Chief Minister Pandey said that the province was paying special attention to connecting the rural areas to production.

The festival is jointly organised by the Walling Chamber of Commerce and Industry and Waling Municipality.

"Villages are becoming empty due to migration. It is necessary to stop the youth in the village, for which they will have to be involved in production," he said.

According to him, the provincial government is working in cooperation with all 85 municipalities to make the upcoming five-year plan of the province production-oriented.

Pandey said that economic development in the country could be possible only with the coordination and cooperation of the three levels of government. He emphasised that everyone's cooperation was necessary to make the province self-reliant.



PHOTO: TRN
Chief Minister of Gandaki Province, Surendra Raj Pandey inaugurating 8th Walling Festival on Thursday in Walling of Syangja district.

CM Pandey said that the fair held at the local level would be important for the preservation of local art and culture.

He said, "Let's make proper use of the local fairs and festivals to make it economically viable so that it can have a good effect on every aspect of economy, culture and everyday life."

The festival started at Waling Stadium and will run for 10 days.

Chet Narayan Shrestha, President of the Walling Chamber of Commerce and Industry, said that the festival was important for the promotion and marketing of local products.

MORE THAN 79,000 FOREIGN TOURISTS VISIT NEPAL IN JANUARY

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

A total of 79,100 foreign tourists arrived in Nepal in January, the first month of 2024.

The number was up by 24,026 as compared to the month of January, 2023.

A total of 55,074 foreign tourists visited Nepal in January, 2023.

> The highest number of Indian tourists (24,139) visited Nepal in January against 16,436 in January, 2023.

According to the Nepal Tourism Board, 81,897 people went out of the country in January.

The highest number of Indian tourists (24,139) visited Nepal in January against 16,436 in January, 2023.

Similarly, 7,267 tourists from China, 7,047 from America, 4,619 from Thailand, 3,812 from South Korea, 3,629 from Bangladesh and 3421 from Australia entered Nepal in January.

Likewise, 3,276 from UK, 2,229 from Bhutan and 1,568 from Japan visited Nepal in the month.

Musk wants Tesla investors to vote on switching carmaker's corporate registration

AP
New York, Feb. 1

Elon Musk wants Tesla investors to decide on moving the company's corporate listing to Texas after a Delaware court decided he shouldn't get a multibillion-dollar pay package.

The electric car company's CEO said early Thursday that Tesla would get shareholders to vote on whether to switch its corporate registration to Texas, where its physical headquarters is located.

"Tesla will move immediately to hold a shareholder vote to transfer state of incorporation to Texas," Musk wrote on his social media platform X, formerly known as Twitter.

Musk had polled X users earlier on the same question, with 87.1% of 1.1 million respondents voting yes. "The public vote is unequivocally in favor of Texas!" he wrote. Musk, who has previously polled people on X before making decisions, moved Tesla's headquarters to Austin, Texas, from California in 2021.

His announcement comes after a judge in Delaware, where the company is currently registered, ruled Tuesday that Musk is not entitled to a landmark compensation package potentially worth more than $55 billion that was awarded by Tesla's board of directors.

After the ruling, Musk took to social media to to express his displeasure.

> The electric car company's CEO said early Thursday that Tesla would get shareholders to vote on whether to switch its corporate registration to Texas, where its physical headquarters is located.

"Never incorporate your company in the state of Delaware," he wrote in one post. He later added, "I recommend incorporating in Nevada or Texas if you prefer shareholders to decide matters."

The ruling came five years after shareholders filed a lawsuit accusing Musk and Tesla directors of breaching their duties and arguing that the pay package was a product of sham negotiations with directors who were not independent of him.

The defense countered that the pay plan was fairly negotiated by a compensation committee whose members were independent and had lofty performance milestones.

Dhankuta's junar cultivation initiative turns awfully sour

BY KABIRAJ GHIMIRE
Hile, Feb. 1

The commercial cultivation of sweet orange (junar) had already started in Dhankuta in the fiscal year 2007/08.

Annually 23.39 tonnes of sweet orange were produced from the cultivation in the area of 229 hectares in the district.

The sweet orange produced here was supplied to neighbouring districts, including Jhapa, Morang and Sunsari.

However, since 2007, the destruction of sweet orange has started in the district. Now, it is very difficult to get sweet orange in Dhankuta, except sweet orange planted for research by the National Citrus Research Programme, Paripatle.

Due to this, Dhankuta, which had started supplying sweet orange itself, now has to bring from Sindhuli, Ramechhap and other districts and consume it.

Orange, which belongs to the category of citrus fruits, is now very famous and popular in Dhankuta. Orange is the main source of income for many farmers.

But in Dhankuta, there is an equal possibility of orange as well as sweet orange.

Sweet orange, which has many characteristics similar to orange, was cultivated commercially until a decade ago. But now the name of sweet orange has been erased in Dhankuta.

Farmers said that till about 2012/13, sweet orange was cultivated in Dhankuta, but it has been completely destroyed since then.

Min Bahadur Karki, a farmer of Dhankuta Municipality-3, said that the orange trees planted in 1997/98 had to be completely destroyed after about 12 years.

"Many people planted sweet orange in the village. About the year of 2006, a type of insect appeared, but nothing could be controlled and it spread to the entire village.

After that, everyone cut the sweet orange plant and threw it away. We have not cultivated it since then," said Karki.

Another farmer Lokendra Parajuli said that farmers did not show their interest to cultivate sweet orange which had been damaged by disease and insects, again.

Orchard wiped out without finding problem

Senior scientist of National Citrus Research Programme, Paripatle Dhankuta Basanta Chalise said that the orchards of sweet orange across Dhankuta have been wiped out within five years.

A kind of insect affecting sweet orange appeared around the year 2006-7 at a time of its flourishing.

The disaster started to be seen all over the gardens.

He said that at first it was difficult to find out which insect had affected it, but later farmers used methyl eugenol, thinking it was Oriental fruit fly, but the insect could not be controlled.

But around 2012/13, it was discovered that the insect affecting the fruit was the Chinese citrus fly. According to him, the treatment method was also discovered, but by that time it was too late.

"Initially, it took time to find out what caused the problem in the fruit, then we thought of another pest and started the treatment method, but it was not successful.

When the pest was discovered, the control method was also discovered, but in the middle of those five years, the farmers had destroyed all the gardens," he said.

Sindhuli and Ramechhap saved

The outbreak of Chinese citrus fly was spread from the east.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Distribution and Consumer Services Directorate
Durbar Marga, Kathmandu, Nepal

Invitation for Electronic Bids (Corrected)

(Date of Publication : 02 February 2024)

This is to notify that the **bid security amount** in the earlier published notice dated 2024 February 01 has been corrected as follows:

IFB No.	Description	Price of Bid Document	Bid Security Amount	Last Date & Time of Bid Submission/Opening
ICB/ DCSD-080/81-02	Supply and Delivery of Steel Tubular Poles for Koshi, Madhesh and Bagmati Province	NPR 20,000.00	NPR 1,50,00,000.00	2024 March 18, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 18, 13:00 Hrs
ICB/ DCSD-080/81-03	Supply and Delivery of Steel Tubular Poles for Gandaki, Lumbini, Karnali and Sudur Paschim Province	NPR 20,000.00	NPR 1,30,00,000.00	2024 March 18, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 18, 13:30 Hrs

For Further details, please visit PPMO's e-GP system: **www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp**

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health and Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division
Pachali, Teku, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice of Intention to Award

Date of Notice : 2 February 2024

Pursuant to clause 27(2) and 47(3) of Public Procurement Act 2063, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive lowest bidders have been selected to award the contract as per the Invitation for Bids published on Gorkhapatra DOHS intends to award the contract to the same.

S.N.	IFB/RFB No.	Item	Name of Successful Bidder	Total Amount CIP
1	DOHS/G/ICB-2/ EDCD/2080-81	Procurement of Rabies Immunoglobulin	**M/S Vins Bioproducts Limited** 806 Essjay House, Road No 3, Banjara Hills Hyderabad India	INR 52,20,000.00

Snowfall, winter rains make life of quake victims more difficult

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rukum West, Feb. 1



Life of earthquake victims in Rukum West has been crippled further after the district started receiving the first winter rains on Thursday morning.

Worse was the situation in the areas where it also snowed.

After the earthquake destroyed their houses, some victims are still living under tarpaulins even about four months after the devastating quake.

The victims have said that they have been suffering more because of snowfall and rain since Thursday morning.

Devakali Pun Magar, an earthquake victim of Chhepare village, Aathbiskot Municipality-14, Rukum West, said that she was greatly worried after it started raining on Wednesday night.

"Cold has increased tremendously," she said. "Children and senior citizens are finding it difficult to cope with the shivering cold under tarpaulins."

Magar said that it was difficult to go out and do necessary works because of the snowfall and rain.

Bijaya Malla of Jamirkot village in Aathbiskot Municipality-14 said that life had become more difficult after it started raining from last night.

According to him, the snowfall accompanied by the winter rain has directly affected the daily life of the earthquake victims. Malla said that as the temporary house he was building was not yet roofed, he was forced to live in his old house full of cracks.

When it started raining, water started leaking from the cracked house, he said, "Fear has increased that the quake-trembled house may collapse anytime, but there is no way out than taking shelter in this risky house," he said.

He complained that the government was unable to complete the task of providing temporary houses for the victims even three months after the earthquake jolted the district.

Manoj Budhathoki, the ward chairman of Sanibheri Rural Municipality-4, said that the daily life of the general people has been affected due to snowfall and rain.

He said that the victims living under tarpaulins and zinc sheets were at high risk after it snowed across the district. Also, it has not stopped raining, he added.

Ward chairman Budhathoki also said that some of the victims were forced to take shelter in their cracked houses.

However, at the same time, the snowfall and winter rain have given them a respite as with the rainfall they could grow their winter crops, especially wheat, maize and barley.

39, 272 punished for driving under influence of alcohol

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

The Traffic Police has taken action against 39,272 people for driving under the influence of alcohol in the last six months in the country.

During the period, 242 people were also found driving under the influence of drugs and penalised.

Of those found driving under the influence of alcohol, 18,627 were from the Kathmandu Valley, 2,524 were from Koshi Province, 2,021 in Madhes, 1,098 from Bagmati, 8,923 from Gandaki, 2,773 from Lumbini, 1,264 from Karnali and 2,042 were from Sudurpashchim Province.

During the period, 81 people in the Kathmandu Valley, 28 in Koshi, 88 in Gandaki, 20 in Lumbini and 25 in Sudurpaschim Province were penalised for driving under the influence of drugs.

Nepal Police Central Spokesperson and Deputy Inspector General of Police Bhim Prasad Dhakal said that Rs.40 million was collected in revenue from the fine imposed on the traffic violators.

He said that priority was given to check drivers for alcohol and drug consumption so as to ensure the safety of passengers, vehicles and the road.

Statistics show that the tendency to drive under the influence of alcohol especially during long-distance journeys leads to sudden and serious accidents. Low presence of traffic police and areas with limited access to CCTV are found with more traffic violators.

"Every driver must drive the vehicle in the right condition to save his/her life and the lives of passengers from accidents," said DIG Dhakal.

Lightning kills octogenarian in Bajura

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bajura, Feb. 1

An octogenarian was killed when he was struck by lightning in Bajura on Wednesday night.

The deceased was identified as 84-year-old Dal Bahadur Budha of Ganjara of Chhededaha Rural Municipality-2 of the district.

District Police Office Bajura said that the old man and his two goats were killed by lightning while he was sleeping in a thatched-roof hut.

According to Acting Chief of the District Police Dan Singh Bhandari, a police team has reached the incident site to collect further details.

Full-size statue of Falgunanda unveiled

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Phidim, Feb. 1



PHOTO: TRN

A statue of Falgunanda Lingden unveil in Khalangatar of Phidim Municipality-10, Panchthar.

A statue of Falgunanda Lingden, the 16th national idol and revered spiritual leader of the Kirant community, was unveiled in Khalangatar of Phidim Municipality-10, Panchthar on Wednesday.

Kirant Dharmaguru Aatmananda Lingden unveiled the full-size statute of Mahaguru Falgunanda.

According to the Construction Committee coordinator Birhangma Thamsuhang, Phidim Municipality contributed Rs. 1 million while Nepalis residing both in the country and abroad funded Rs. 3 million to build the statue.

On the occasion, Dharmaguru Lingden said that the Yakthung Limbu community was lagging in social and educational sectors as they had failed to follow the paths shown by Mahaguru Lingden.

He said, "The community still practices drinking and sleeping on the roadside like a drunkard. Until the habit is improved, we cannot be victorious in any competition organised in home and abroad."

Three new BOPs built in Jhapa

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Birtamode, Feb. 1

Armed Police Force Nepal has constructed three Border Out Posts (BOPs) in Jhapa district.

Permanent structures of BOPs have been built for the Armed Police Force, which is given the responsibility of border security.

Two BOPs have been added in the Gaurigunj Rural Municipality and one in Kachanawakal, according to the APF.

BOP Lalmati in Gaurigunj-2, BOP Altamari in Gaurigunj-4, and BOP Dagabari in Kachankawal-5 have been established to enhance international security.

The newly constructed BOPs were jointly inaugurated by former Chief Minister of Koshi Province Hikmat Kumar Karki, Chief of the Armed Police Force No. 1 Baraha Brigade and Deputy Inspector General of APF Anjani Kumar Pokharel.

Superintendent of Police and chief of the Armed Police Force No. 2 Devraj Aryal said that the concrete structures of three BOPs were jointly inaugurated at an event held at BOP Lalmati.

SP Aryal said that four Companies and 17 BOPs are there for border security in Jhapa. He further added that proposals have been made to construct additional BOPs in 15 different locations in the district that borders India in a stretch of 144.2 km.

DIG Pokharel said that the Armed Police could easily mitigate crimes taking place at the border area with the construction of new BOPs.

Pokharel said that the armed police were working with zero tolerance in the border area with the motive of reducing cross-border crimes.

Former Chief Minister of Koshi Province, Karki said that even though the BOPs have been constructed, the government needed to work for their management as they still lacked essential equipment.

BOP Lalmati has been built on seven kattha land given by local Binita Nemwang Limbu. The concrete building of the new BOP was built for Rs. 10.9 million.

Likewise, BOP Altamari has been built on five kattha of land donated by Babita Kumari Sah, and the structure of the BOP was built for Rs. 8.3 million, and BOP in Dangibari has been built on the land given by local Upendra Prasad Acharya of Dangibari for Rs. 8.3 million.



PHOTO: TRN

Hikmat Kumar Karki, former Chief Minister of Koshi province, and Deputy Inspector General of APF Anjani Kumar Pokharel jointly inaugurating newly constructed BOPs in Jhapa.

Monkeys trapped in Dhanusha settlements, released in forest

VIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Feb. 1



PHOTO: TRN

Trapped monkeys in cage at Dhanusha.

The monkeys which were annoying the farmers by eating their food crops, vegetables and fruits in Bateshwar Rural Municipality-1, Chitrapur of Dhanusha, were caught and released into the forest.

Three experienced monkey catchers were brought from Mathura, India, to apprehend the troublesome monkeys which were causing a nuisance to the locals of Chitrapur.

Ward chairman Ashok Kumar Mahato said that they captured over 500 monkeys from the settlements and farms and relocated them to the Chure forest within a month. He added that they trapped the monkeys in cages and transported them away from the settlements to the forest during the night.

Bhula Kesari of Mathura, a monkey catcher, explained that bananas, almonds, gram, fruits, and other foods were placed inside the cage as bait. Once the monkeys entered the cage out of greed for food, they were securely closed and taken to a safe location for release, he added.

He explained, "Initially, we entice the monkeys by offering food. Then, we secure them in a cage. By employing this method and releasing them in a safe forest, the monkeys remain unharmed."

For the past few years, due to the dense vegetation in Chitrapur village, monkeys have been entering fields and causing damage to crops, vegetables, and fruits. Additionally, they have been entering houses and causing further damage.

A month ago, locals, who were enduring the havoc caused by monkeys, locked the ward office, demanding that the monkey menace be controlled. Following this, Ward Chairman Mahato invited an experienced individual from Mathura, India, to address the issue.

Bateshwar Rural Municipality allocated Rs. 500,000 to mitigate the monkey menace.

Locals expressed relief after the monkeys were successfully driven away, although they remain concerned about the continued presence of Nilgai (blue cow) which still poses a threat to their crops.

Rs. 80 million allocated to upgrade Ganeshman Road

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

Ganeshman Road (Thankot-Chitalng road section) has been inspected after the Finance Ministry allocated a budget to upgrade it.

The Finance Ministry at the special request of the Mayor of Chandragiri Municipality had, on January 26, allocated Rs. 80 million to forward upgrading activities of the route immediately.

Meanwhile, a team comprising Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport, Prakash Jwala, Mayor Giri, Deputy Mayor Basanti Shrestha and Municipality Spokesperson Krishna Prasad Khadgi inspected the Ganeshman Road on Wednesday.

Five people were killed in a car accident that took place at Setopaharo along the road section on January 23.

Five people were killed in a car accident that took place at Setopaharo along the road section on January 23.

In the course of the inspection, Minister Jwala directed the bodies concerned to upgrade the road immediately and carry out activities to complete its construction in time.

He urged the bodies concerned to carry out activities by completing the legal process at the earliest as protecting the lives of the people was the first responsibility of the government.

Similarly, Mayor Giri thanked the Finance Minister for allocating the budget to forward the upgrading works of the Ganeshman Road.

Uttarganga Power Company Limited
(Subsidiary Company of Nepal Electricity Authority)
Tripureswor, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notification of Award

(Date of Publication: February 02, 2024)

This is to notify all the Sealed Quotation Bidders for execution of "**Supply and Delivery of Motorcycle and Scooter, Sealed Quotation No. UGPCL-2080/81-SQ-01"** that **MAW Enterprises Pvt. Ltd, Tripureswor, Kathmandu** sealed Quotation Dated 2080/10/04 (January 18 2024) for the contract price of Nrs. 9,58,240.00 (Nine Lakhs Fifty Eight Thousand Two Hundred and Forty Rupees Only) inclusive of VAT as corrected in accordance with the Instructions to Bidders is hereby accepted in accordance with the Instructions to Bidders.
The Selected bidder is instructed to contact this office to sign the formal contract agreement within 7 days of this Notice along with Performance Security as specified in SCC, consisting of a Bank Guarantee in the format included in Section VIII (Contract Forms) of the Bidding Document.
The Purchaser shall forfeit the bid security, in case the bidder fails to furnish the Performance Security and to sign the Contract Agreement within the specified period.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

If you tell the truth, you don't have to remember anything.
-- Mark Twain

EDITORIAL

Revive Hetauda Textile

Nepal can well be a hub of textile manufacturing, given the low labour cost and growing supply of cheap electricity. The Nepal Army's keenness to revive the long-closed Hetauda Textile Factory (HTF) holds promise for the country's garment sector. Having been in several businesses alongside being involved in countless development works like road construction for a long time now, the NA is sure to have developed a crucial acumen to successfully run an industry of national pride. But without deep understanding of the past shortcomings that caused the factory to go bust some 25 years ago and thoroughly learning its lessons, the revival effort may encounter unforeseen setbacks. That much of the tools and machines, including sewing machines, in the mill are still functional will surely lower the investment needed to give it a new lease of life.

Overstaffing, managerial failures, lack of ability to compete with similar products manufactured elsewhere both in quality and price, crippling power shortages, among other factors, are cited as reasons that brought the HTF to its eventual closure. One widely known reason that had made our products up to '30 per cent' more expensive than our rival clothes woven in India or China for example is a heavy export subsidy lavished on them by their state governments. If needed, the government shouldn't hesitate to provide such a subsidy to offset that problem.

After all, an apparel attractive in design, sturdy in quality and affordable in price will find no shortage of buyers. But, missing of any one of these attributes will make it a hard sell. If making it appealing enough to persuade the buyers means providing training to factory workers abroad, the option must be embraced. The global apparel industry is worth about $2 trillion dollars, and being able to grab a tiny share of it would bring untold prosperity. There are already a growing number of homegrown textile producers – like Sonam gears – that have become highly successful in giving their international competitors a run for their money and build a formidable customer base. Taking a leaf out of their book can be helpful.

Learning from neighbouring Bangladesh's example can also be valuable. Once an impoverished nation, it has grown to become the world's biggest garment exporter, after China, lifting millions out of poverty and significantly improving the standard of people's living. But the dire power shortage it has faced in recent years has threatened even its crown jewel industry: textile. This explains why Bangladesh has been keen to import electricity from Nepal.

Once resuscitated, the HTF will encourage Nepalis to use the textile made in the country. In addition, it will also be able to supply the garments required for security agencies of the government – Nepal Army, Nepal Police, Armed Police Force – all of whom need tonnes of garment every year for its ranks. There is one more benefit: the factory will provide livelihoods to countless farmers who grow raw materials needed for the factory. As employment opportunities increase, not only will it check the exodus of our youths for foreign employment, it will also substitute our imports and enhance self-reliance. It will also increase the country's appeal as a growing manufacturing powerhouse. It can even draw multi-national companies that are increasingly pivoting away from countries where labour cost has gone so high that they no longer appeal to foreign investors.

Brawls In Parliament

BINI DAHAL

Not long ago, the Maldivian parliament was in real havoc when its members began physically assaulting one another. Photos and videos circulated through the media clearly portrays the situation. In a video, lawmakers are found playing toy trumpets and punching, kicking and pulling each other's hair. It is said that one of the member had to be taken to hospital as he had sustained injuries.

All this happened on a day where the parliament was planning to approve four of the Cabinet ministers. These individuals belong to the Maldivian Democratic Party (MDP) of the newly-elected President of the country. However, the members of the opposition party People's National Congress (PNC) were reluctant to extend their support to the ruling party. And this caused disruptions to the House. The governing party has said that not allowing the ministers to be appointed was affecting the public service delivery of the country.

Reading about such ugly brawls in the parliament does not come off as a shock. Over the years, members of parliament in different countries have fought with one another for different reasons. Even in Nepal, the 2015 brawl in parliament is quite memorable. Then, during the process of drafting the constitution, members from the opposition party had disrupted the House. The Speaker had also been attacked. Chairs had been broken and microphones had been thrown away. It was even reported that several of the security guards had suffered injuries.

Why do parliamentary members act in such a manner? Limited research has been conducted and to some extent they can help answer the question. One of the key researches has shown that parliamentary scuffles take place based on levels of electoral democracy and the composition of the parliament. So, it is said that most of the time, parliamentarians fight in hybrid or intermediate regimes. Hybrid regimes basically mean that the regime is neither fully authoritarian nor highly democratic in nature.

With such fights, the political parties want to achieve certain political objectives. So this means, it could be used to change the public perception or prevent certain laws and constitutional amendments from happening. The outcome of such a brawl is not exactly good as it is said that it changes the perception of voters in a negative manner.

Considering these research-based points, we can see that in the case of the Maldives and our own, there is a fragmentation in parliaments. The disintegration is between the majority and the minority. In the Maldives, the two-third majority is held by the opposition party while the ruling party is a minority. Therefore, a continuous tussle between the party in power and the opposition ones brings about conflict and violence. Such behaviour can be termed problematic as it develops a very negative image. If we look at the issue through the lens of democracy, physical violence is seen as a challenge to the real sense and spirit of democracy.

In a situation as such, strengthening democratic institutions is very important to stop conflicts from happening. As elected representatives of the people, it is crucial that the members of the parliament be responsible towards the people. Focusing on petty interests of their own and their respective political parties can never be good for a country. They must not forget that the people have voted them to parliament to work for bringing about desired changes in the nation and not for washing their dirty linen in public.

Tap Potential Of High-altitude Wetlands

Ramesh Timilsina



Srijana Joshi



On the full moon day of the warm monsoon period in August every year, the Janai Purnima sacred thread festival takes place in Nepal. Devotees across the country perform ancient rites at holy waterspouts, while pilgrims flock to the alpine freshwater wetland of Gosaikunda lake, in Langtang National Park, north-central Nepal. It is believed that this crystal-clear lake was created by Lord Shiva, one of the principal gods of Hinduism. Looking down on the beauty of this valley, it's easy to see why Gosaikunda is considered the abode of gods in Hindu mythology. The lake holds great significance for both Hindus and Buddhists, symbolising unity between these communities; pilgrims believe that a dip in its sacred waters brings spiritual purification and redemption from sin.

As illustrated here in Gosaikunda, wetlands have formed the cradle of civilisations across the Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH), shaping cultural identities, playing an important role in ensuring water and food security, increasing resilience to climate change, supporting livelihoods, and securing habitats for different species of plants and animals. Wetlands account for 10 per cent of the HKH, and the region is home to the largest number of high-altitude wetlands globally. High-altitude wetlands are found at elevations above 3000 metres above sea level; these ecosystems encompass a variety of forms, including glacial lakes, alpine meadows, and peatlands.

Ramsar sites

Wetland sites of international importance are known as 'Ramsar sites', named after the 'Convention on Wetlands' which took place in Ramsar, Iran, in 1971, under the auspices of UNESCO, providing national action and international cooperation regarding the conservation of wetlands, and wise sustainable use of their resources. Of the 44 designated Ramsar sites in the HKH, 21 are high-altitude wetlands.

However, complex development dynamics, coupled with limited awareness of the contribution made by wetlands to societal wellbeing, has put tremendous pressure on wetlands. Wetlands continue to be degraded and lost due to conversion for alternate uses, fragmentation of hydrological regimes, pollution, species invasion, unsustainable tourism, overharvesting of resources and regional climate change. Taking into account growing food and water security across South Asia, it is crucial for regional and national policymakers to focus greater attention on the integrated management of wetlands.

The frequency of natural disasters in South Asia is increasingly showing an upward trend. According to the Global Risk Analysis Report, about half of the total South Asian population are at 'relatively high mortality risk' from natural disasters. Water-related disasters are the most destructive of all natural disasters, and it is likely that these will become more frequent and intense in the future.

> High-altitude wetlands in the HKH region are vital for local communities, serving as a crucial freshwater source for drinking, irrigation, and livestock.

WORLD WETLANDS DAY

High-altitude wetlands in the HKH region are vital for local communities, serving as a crucial freshwater source for drinking, irrigation, and livestock. Indigenous groups rely on traditional practices including yak herding and medicinal plant collection, which form the core of their livelihoods. The cultural and spiritual significance of these wetlands is profound, as they are sacred sites entrusted to collective preservation across generations. However, their contribution to human wellbeing is often understated, and the destruction and degradation of wetlands in the region continues.

Along with the current triple planetary crisis of climate change, pollution and biodiversity loss, humanity is experiencing a growing wellbeing challenge. Mental health issues such as depression, anxiety, and non-communicable diseases like obesity, asthma, and heart disease are on the rise, particularly in the post-COVID-19 era.

Several studies suggest that nature plays a role in relieving symptoms in individuals experiencing poor mental health. Greenery and wetlands have been associated with reduction in stress, improvements in cognitive functioning, increase in self-esteem, and reduced depression and anxiety. 'Blue spaces', defined as environments that predominantly consist of water, have been shown to be better at promoting well-being than green spaces, across a broad range of mental health indicators.

Additionally, high levels of biodiversity and species richness of wetlands have been shown to be positively associated with self-reported psychological wellbeing. The connections between wetlands and human wellbeing need to be recognised and they must be valued as sites for improved human wellbeing rather than being described merely as water sources or dismissed as 'wastelands'.

Sustainable practices

Numerous organisations and government bodies are dedicated to conserving high-altitude wetlands in the HKH through community-based projects, sustainable tourism, and research. Recognising their significance and adopting sustainable practices is not just an ecological responsibility but also a means of safeguarding the wellbeing and livelihoods of local communities and visitors.

In line with this year's theme for World Wetlands Day – 'Wetlands and human wellbeing' – it is crucial to recognise the valuable contributions of wetlands to human wellbeing, and there is an urgent need to identify, document, and profile these sites. By bringing them into the limelight, we can raise awareness of their importance for mental and spiritual wellbeing and foster a culture of conservation and sustainable tourism.

(Timilsina is a Rangeland Research Associate and Joshi an Ecosystem Specialist at International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD)

Scaling Up TB Free Initiative

Jhabindra Bhandari



Globally, TB is a major public health challenge. However, TB is preventable and usually curable disease. Caused by the bacillus *Mycobacterium tuberculosis*, it is spread when people who are sick with TB expel bacteria into the air. About a quarter of the global population is estimated to have been infected with TB. Drug-resistant TB continues to be a serious public health threat. More importantly, TB is a social disease and its understanding demands profound impacts of historical, social, cultural, and economic on individuals and communities. Needless to say, TB is a disease of poverty with prolonged socio-economic distress, vulnerability, marginalisation, stigma and discrimination. Therefore, it is necessary to consider differential effects of TB in terms of socio-economic status, gender, migration, and other socio-demographic variables.

Considering the urgency of effective and sustained TB response, National TB Control Centre (NTCC) has been consistently implementing National TB Programme (NTP) with the additional technical support from WHO, Global Fund, and other implementing partners at all levels. Over the years, the NTCC has been proactively engaged in formulating policies, strategies, and relevant technical guidelines to ensure quality assurance as well as scaling up research and innovations for sustained national TB response.

Development challenge

Ending TB is not just a public health problem, but a development challenge. Therefore, national strategic plan to end TB (2021/22-205/26) has largely focused on integrated patient-centred care and prevention which aims to ensure early detection, treatment and prevention for all TB patients including children. Moreover, it is necessary to ensure all people have equal and unhindered access to affordable services, and they engage in their care.

Likewise, there are significant efforts to strengthen health and social sector policies and supportive systems by accelerating the progress on Universal Health Coverage (UHC), social protection and regulatory frameworks for case notification, vital registration, quality and rational use of medicines, and infection control. In addition, the strategic priorities also focus on operational research for the design, implementation, and scaling-up of innovations. In this context, TB free initiative is one of the strategic priorities to make the local governments more accountable towards the ambitious target of ending TB. The NTCC has developed a comprehensive guideline for TB free initiative to effectively plan and implement activities related to active TB case finding, diagnosis, prevention, treatment, care and support in the federal context.

This clear shows Nepal's strong political commitment for implementation of the TB free initiative to ensure all people with TB have access to quality care through the UHC. The initiative also aims to strengthen community engagement for the meaningful participation of TB patients, promotion of human rights and patient support in national response. While there are significant efforts to include TB patients and their families in health insurance package and social protection services, it is important to address the social determinants of TB and focus interventions for vulnerable groups such as very poor, people living with HIV, diabetes, disability and migrants.

Therefore, one of the important features of TB free initiative is to enhance political leadership, commitment, ownership, multi-sector engagement and partnership for a coordinated response to end TB. While there is still a funding gap for the NTP, local governments can prioritise their resources for continuity and sustainability of TB services. As of now, the TB free initiative is implemented in 25 municipalities and it will be scaled up in additional 100 municipalities soon.

> Reaching out to key and vulnerable populations should be one of the key strategies of the TB free initiative to effectively address the structural inequalities and barriers they face in accessing TB services for years.

In order to ensure participatory and inclusive planning and implementation of TB free initiative, there are specific committees responsible for providing technical support in micro-planning for multi-sector actions at all levels. However, there is critical need to strengthen the capacity of local governments and the committees in developing a profile of TB patients, micro-planning, resource mobilisation, monitoring and evaluation of TB diagnosis, prevention, treatment, care and support. Undoubtedly, TB free initiative demands sustained political commitment, meaningful community engagement, respect for human rights, gender inclusion and equity considerations. Within local health systems, it is important to ensure provision of high quality integrated care to all patients with TB, including diagnostics and treatment services across public and private sectors. Integrating TB services help gain efficiency and access to treatment and care.

Multi-sectoral action

As TB is driven by social, cultural and economic determinants, multi-sectoral action is necessary to address them through community-led interventions. This also generates local evidence to strengthen TB response in the communities. Beyond health sector, it is necessary to establish a multi-sector accountability framework for coordinated actions with all sectors. Working with civil society is instrumental in strengthening community engagement and leveraging their capacities to end TB. Furthermore, people affected by TB can play key role in implementation of TB free initiative at community level.

During COVID-19 pandemic and other disasters, the civil society and their networks in the communities have played critical role in maintaining access to essential health care. Recovery from the pandemic and other health emergencies during disasters demands resilient communities to realistically face complex livelihood challenges and rebound from the huge number of missing people with TB due to the disruptions. Additionally, the use of digital technologies can be helpful to support psychosocial well-being, patient rights, and adherence to TB treatment and improve better health outcomes. Reaching out to key and vulnerable populations should be one of the key strategies of the TB free initiative to effectively address the structural inequalities and barriers they face in accessing TB services for years.

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 2, 1974

Baitadi Has Nine Secondary Schools

Mahendranagar, Feb. 1: Baitadi district has the highest number of secondary schools in Mahakali Zone, reports RSS

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P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Strict Law Helps Reduce Drunk Driving

This is in reference to a news report titled "*39k punished for driving under influence of alcohol*" published in the digital edition of your prestigious daily on Thursday.

According to the news report, in the last six months, the traffic police has taken action against 39,272 individuals for driving under the influence of alcohol.

Around 18,627 from Kathmandu Valley, 2,524 from Koshi Province, 2,021 in Madhesh, 1,098 in Bagmati, 8,923 in Gandaki, 2,773 in Lumbini, 1,264 in Karnali and 2,042 in Sudur Paschim Province were found drunk driving.

The police was able to collect a total of Rs. 40 million in revenue from the fine imposed on the traffic violators.

This clearly highlights that driving under the influence of alcohol is a major issue in the country.



Despite constant monitoring and the imposition of fines, it is evident that a large number of drivers drink and drive. This can lead to accidents and people can lose their lives.

In such a situation, the government and the concerned authorities should implement strict rules and regulations and reduce such figures immediately.

The police should continue monitoring specially the long distance driving vehicles and their drivers.

Anusha Karki
New Baneshwor, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A tour bus driver is driving with a bus full of old aged pensioners when he is tapped on his shoulder by a little old lady.

She offers him a handful of peanuts, which he gratefully munches up.

After about 15 minutes, she taps him on the shoulder again and she hands the driver another handful of peanuts.

When she is about to hand him another batch again, he asks her "Why don't you eat the peanuts?"

"We can't chew them because we have no teeth", she replied.

"We just love the chocolate around them."

Israel and Lebanon prepping for a war neither wants

AP
Beirut, Feb. 1

The prospect of a full-scale war between Israel and Lebanon's Hezbollah militia terrifies people on both sides of the border, but some see it as an inevitable fallout from Israel's ongoing war against Hamas in Gaza.

Such a war could be the most destructive either side has ever experienced.

Israel and Hezbollah each have lessons from their last war, in 2006, a month-long conflict that ended in a draw. They've also had four months to prepare for another war, even as the United States tries to prevent a widening of the conflict.

Here's a look at each side's preparedness, how war might unfold and what's being done to prevent it.

The 2006 war, six years after Israeli forces withdrew from south Lebanon, erupted after Hezbollah captured two Israeli soldiers and killed several others in a cross-border raid.

Israel launched a full-scale air and ground offensive and imposed a blockade that aimed to free the hostages and destroy Hezbollah's military capabilities — a mission that ultimately failed.

Israeli bombing levelled large swaths of south Lebanon and Beirut's southern suburbs. Hezbollah fired thousands of unguided rockets into northern Israel communities.

The conflict killed some 1,200 Lebanese, mostly civilians, and 160 Israelis, mostly soldiers.

A United Nations resolution ending the war called for withdrawal of Israeli forces from Lebanon and a demilitarized zone on Lebanon's side of the border.

Despite the deployment of U.N. peacekeepers, Hezbollah continues to operate in the border area, while Lebanon says Israel regularly violates its airspace and continues to occupy pockets of Lebanese land.

An Israel-Hezbollah war "would be a total disaster," U.N. Secretary-General Antonio Guterres warned last month, amid a flurry of shuttle diplomacy by the U.S. and Europe.

Iran-backed Hezbollah seemed caught off-guard by Hamas' Oct. 7 attack on Israel, a regional ally. Since then, Hezbollah and Israel have exchanged daily cross-border strikes, escalating gradually. Israel also carried out targeted killings of Hezbollah and Hamas figures in Lebanon.

More than 200 people, mostly Hezbollah fighters but also more than 20 civilians, have been killed on Lebanon's side, and 18 on Israel's.



PHOTO: AP

Spanish U.N. peacekeepers stand on a hill overlooking the Lebanese border villages with Israel in Marjayoun town on Wednesday, Jan. 10, 2024.

Tens of thousands have been displaced on both sides. There are no immediate prospects for their return.

Israeli political and military leaders have warned Hezbollah that war is increasingly probable unless the militants withdraw from the border.

Hezbollah leader Hassan Nasrallah hasn't threatened to initiate war but warned of a fight "without limits" if Israel does. Hezbollah says it won't agree to a ceasefire on the Israel-Lebanon border before there's one in Gaza and has rebuffed a U.S. proposal to move its forces several kilometres (miles) back from the border, according to Lebanese officials.

Despite the rhetoric, neither side appears to want war, said Andrea Tenenti, spokesperson for the U.N. peacekeeping mission in south Lebanon. However, "a miscalculation could potentially trigger a wider conflict that would be very difficult to control," he said.

Both Hezbollah and the Israeli military have expanded capabilities since 2006 — yet both countries also are more fragile.

In Lebanon, four years of economic crisis have crippled public institutions, including its army and electrical grid, and eroded its health system. The country hosts more than 1 million Syrian refugees.

Lebanon adopted an emergency plan for a war scenario in late October. It projected the forcible displacement of 1 million Lebanese for 45 days.

About 87,000 Lebanese are displaced from the border area. While the government is relying on international organizations to fund the response, many groups working in Lebanon can't maintain existing programs.

ROHINGYA FLEEING MYANMAR BY BOAT

AP
Sydney, Feb. 1

Across a treacherous stretch of water, the Rohingya came by the thousands, then died by the hundreds. And though they know the dangers of fleeing by boat, many among this persecuted people say they will not stop — because the world has left them with no other choice.

Last year, nearly 4,500 Rohingya — two-thirds of them women and children — fled their homeland of Myanmar and the refugee camps in neighbouring Bangladesh by boat, the United Nations' refugee agency reported. Of those, 569 died or went missing while crossing the Bay of Bengal and Andaman Sea, the highest death toll since 2014.

The numbers mean one out of every eight Rohingya who attempted the crossing never made it, the UNHCR said last week.

Yet despite the risks, there are no signs the stream of Rohingya is ebbing. On Thursday, Indonesian officials said another boat carrying Rohingya refugees landed in the country's northern province of Aceh.

Fishermen provided food and water to 131 Rohingya, mostly women and children, who had been on board, said Marzuki, the leader of the local tribal fishing community, who like many Indonesians goes by one name.

Some passengers told officials they had been at sea since last month and their boat's engine had broken down, leaving them adrift, said Lt. Col. Andi Susanto, commander of the navy base in Lhokseumawe.

UN's Guterres urges return to civilian rule in Myanmar



PHOTO: AFP

United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres.

AFP
United Nations, Feb. 1

United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres called Thursday for an end to violence in Myanmar and a return to democracy, three years to the day since the military seized power in a coup that toppled Nobel laureate Aung San Suu Kyi's government.

"On this sombre anniversary, the Secretary-General underscores the urgency of forging a path towards a democratic transition with a return to civilian rule," Guterres' spokesman Stephane Dujarric said in a statement.

The UN's plea came a day after Myanmar's embattled junta extended a state of emergency by six months, once again delaying promised elections.

Due to expire at midnight, the state of emergency was kept in place to "continue the process of combatting terrorists", the junta said in a statement.

Speaking ahead of the coup anniversary, junta chief Min Aung Hlaing said the military would do "whatever it takes" to crush opposition to its rule.

More than 4,400 people have been killed in the military's crackdown since security forces rounded up Suu Kyi and lawmakers from her National League for Democracy (NLD) party in the early hours of February 1, 2021.

In the days following the coup, huge marches were met by a brutal and sustained crackdown that sent thousands of protesters seeking ways to fight back.

Clashes and reprisals have ravaged swathes of Myanmar since, forcing more than two million people to flee their homes, according to the UN.

Open dissent on the streets of major urban centres has been all but stamped out by the junta's bullets, batons and networks of undercover police and informants.

But across swathes of the country, the military is struggling to crush resistance to its rule.

Anti-coup "People's Defence Forces" that sprang up in the wake of the crackdown have surprised the military with their effectiveness, analysts say, and have dragged its troops into a bloody quagmire.

And in late October, an alliance of ethnic minority fighters launched a surprise offensive in northern Shan state, capturing swathes of territory and taking control of lucrative trade routes to China.

Anti-coup "People's Defence Forces" that sprang up in the wake of the crackdown have surprised the military with their effectiveness, analysts say, and have dragged its troops into a bloody quagmire.

A Beijing-brokered peace deal has since paused the fighting in the north, but the alliance has largely kept its recent gains and clashes continue elsewhere.

The cascade of setbacks has dented morale among low- and mid-level officers, according to several military sources contacted by AFP, all of whom requested anonymity.

The human rights situation in Myanmar is in "free-fall," the United Nations rights chief said this week.

Junta groups have torched villages, carried out extrajudicial killings and used air strikes and artillery bombardments to punish communities opposed to its rule, opponents and rights groups say.

The junta has targeted media deemed critical of the coup and subsequent crackdown, revoking licenses and arresting and jailing dozens of journalists.

With 43 journalists languishing behind bars last year, Myanmar was the world's second-worst jailer of journalists in 2023, according to the Committee to Protect Journalists, behind only China.

Diplomatic efforts to end the conflict led by the United Nations and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations regional bloc have made no headway.

On Wednesday, the United States announced fresh sanctions on two entities "closely associated with Burma's military regime" as well as four individuals.

They include the Shwe Byain Phyu Group of Companies and shipping firm Myanma Five Star Line Company Limited.

EU agrees on 50 billion-euro aid package for Ukraine



PHOTO: AP

Slovakia's Prime Minister Robert Fico, right, talks to Hungary's Prime Minister Viktor Orban during a round table meeting at an EU summit in Brussels, Thursday, Feb. 1, 2024.

AP
Brussels, Feb. 1

A top European Union official says the 27 EU countries have sealed a deal on new aid for Ukraine just over an hour into a summit of the bloc's leaders and despite threats from Hungary to veto the move.

"We have a deal," European Council President Charles Michel said in a post on X, formerly known as Twitter. He wrote that all "27 leaders agreed on an additional 50-billion-euro ($54 billion) support package for Ukraine within the EU budget."

The announcement came despite staunch objections from Hungary in December and in the days leading up to Thursday's summit in Brussels. It was not immediately clear if any concessions were made to secure Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban's approval.

Michel said that the move "locks in steadfast, long-term, predictable funding for Ukraine," and demonstrates that the "EU is taking leadership and responsibility in support for Ukraine; we know what is at stake."

Meanwhile, EU leaders lashed out at Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban on Thursday, accusing him of blackmail and playing political games that undermine support for Ukraine as his nationalist government holds up EU financial aid for the country's war-ravaged economy.

Almost two years after Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the war has ground to a halt and Ukraine's economy desperately needs propping up. But political infighting in the EU and in the United States is depriving Kyiv of a long-term source of funding. More than $100 billion is being held up.

Concern has mounted that public support to keep pouring money into Ukraine has started to wane, even though a Russian victory could threaten security across Europe.

"There is no problem with the so-called Ukraine fatigue issue. We have Orban fatigue now in Brussels," Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk told reporters at an EU summit. "I can't understand. I can't accept this very strange and very egoistic game of Viktor Orban."

PRISM

11-year-old boy breaks fingerboarding record

Virginia: An 11-year-old Virginia boy earned a Guinness World Record for the most ollies on a fingerboard in 1 minute.

Julian Kuczma of Chesapeake said he was introduced to fingerboards -- miniature skateboards designed to be manipulated by the fingers -- by his friends and some YouTube videos.

"I started trying to do tricks on them and picked it up pretty quickly," Kuczma told Guinness World Records. "I would fingerboard just about everywhere I would go; at school during lunch, at home, and even when my mom forced me to go shopping with her and my sister."

Kuczma decided to challenge the Guinness World Record for the most ollies on a fingerboard in 1 minute. An ollie is a trick where all four wheels of the board leave the ground and come back down to land.

Kuczma successfully broke the record with 128 ollies in 1 minute. He said he is considering taking on more fingerboarding records in the future.

Deer rescued from narrow gap between houses

London: Firefighters and animal rescuers in Britain came to the rescue of a deer found wedged upside-down in a narrow gap between two houses.

The RSPCA said personnel responded alongside the Lincolnshire Fire and Rescue Service when the muntjac deer was found stuck in Lough.

The rescuers used ropes and poles to gently pull the deer to safety.

"This was a tricky rescue because the deer was trapped so tightly and to complicate matters was also upside down -- it must have been terrifying for him. Thankfully he was freed and it was such a relief to watch him run free into the undergrowth," Animal Rescue Officer Karen Nix said in an RSPCA news release.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

506 – Alaric II, eighth king of the Visigoths, promulgates the Breviary of Alaric (Breviarium Alaricianum or Lex Romana Visigothorum), a collection of "Roman law".
1032 – Conrad II, Holy Roman Emperor becomes king of Burgundy.
1141 – The Battle of Lincoln, at which Stephen, King of England is defeated and captured by the allies of Empress Matilda.[2]
1207 – Terra Mariana, eventually comprising present-day Latvia and Estonia, is established.
1461 – Wars of the Roses: The Battle of Mortimer's Cross results in the death of Owen Tudor.
1536 – Spaniard Pedro de Mendoza founds Buenos Aires, Argentina.
1653 – New Amsterdam (later renamed The City of New York) is incorporated.
1709 – Alexander Selkirk is rescued after being shipwrecked on a desert island, inspiring Daniel Defoe's adventure book Robinson Crusoe.
1900 – Boston, Detroit, Milwaukee, Baltimore, Chicago and St. Louis, agree to form baseball's American League.

Climate activist Thunberg arrives for London trial

AFP
London, Feb. 1

Environmental activist Greta Thunberg arrived at a London court on Thursday, where she faces public order charges linked to a demonstration against the energy industry.

Supporters were already gathered outside Westminster Magistrates' Court in central London when the 21-year-old Swedish campaigner arrived around an hour before the 10:00 am (1000 GMT) start of her two-day trial.

They held large yellow signs reading "fossil free London" and "climate protest is not a crime" as Thunberg and her fellow defendants made their way through the throng and into the court building.



A global figure in the fight against climate change, Thunberg pleaded not guilty to the charges at an initial hearing in November, as did four other activists who are her co-defendants.

Thunberg, who faces a maximum fine of £2,500 ($3,177), was taken away by two police officers and put into the back of a van outside the Energy Intelligence Forum, after she joined a mass protest.

She was one of dozens of activists arrested for disrupting access to the conference, which brought together major oil and gas companies at a luxury hotel in the British capital on October 17.

Demonstrators greeted the forum participants with cries of "Shame on you!" while carrying placards reading "Stop Rosebank", a reference to a controversial new North Sea oil field that the government authorised in September.

London police arrested Thunberg for failing to adhere to an order not to block the street where the rally was taking place.

Released on bail, she then took part in another demonstration in front of the five-star hotel the next day, along with hundreds of other people.

Maja Darlington, campaigner at Greenpeace UK, said the activists were on trial "for peacefully protesting" while oil executives were "celebrating making billions from selling climate-wrecking fossil fuels.

"The prosecution of Greta and other peaceful protesters reflects a government that cares more about bolstering the profits of oil bosses than fighting for a liveable future for all of us," she added.

Suspension bridge record span being built over Kaligandaki River

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Baglung, Feb. 1

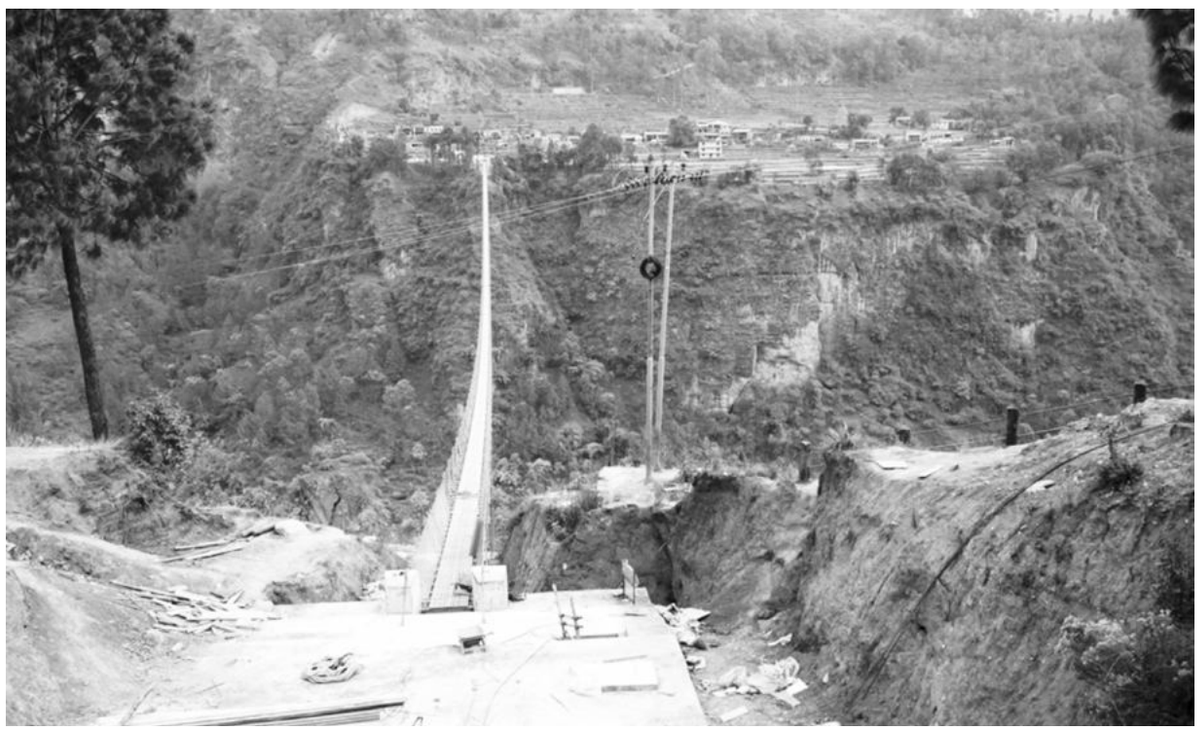


PHOTO: THAKUR PRASAD ACAHRYA/TRN
The construction of a 524-metre-long suspension bridge over the Kaligandaki River in Baglung district will be completed within a few weeks.

Construction of a 524-metre-long suspension bridge over the Kaligandaki River has reached its final stage. It is expected to be completed within a few weeks, four months ahead of the deadline.

The bridge connects Gauridham of Baglung Municipality-4 and Odare of Jaljala Rural Municipality-8 in Baglung district.

Suspension Bridge Division Office in Lalitpur informed that 95 per cent of the construction has been completed. The office assigned the contact to Himsikhar Hira Construction Company on July 5, 2022, for Rs. 82.34 million (excluding VAT).

Basanta Gharti Magar, the main representative of the construction company, said, "Almost all structural components of the bridge have been constructed. Once the cables are tensioned, we will install the flooring on both sides of the bridge. We are working rapidly to complete all remaining tasks and make it operational within the next three weeks."

The bridge is claimed to be the second-longest single-span suspension bridge in the world.

Ward No. 4 chairman Kumar Bikram Chhetri said that the bridge would significantly reduce the travel time for locals and traders in the Jaljala area to reach Baglung Bazaar.

He said, "It takes around 1.5 hours for Jaljala locals to reach Baglung Bazaar by foot. After the bridge comes into operation, the travel time will be reduced to 15 minutes." Additionally, the bridge is expected to attract tourists due to its long and tall features.

Nepali doctors draw accolades for successful liver transplant

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

In a ground-breaking achievement, Nepali doctors and healthcare professionals at the Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital (TUTH) in Maharajgunj have successfully performed the first-ever liver transplantation solely relying on a local team. The milestone surgery took place on January 12, led by the team led by liver transplant specialist Dr. Ramesh Singh Bhandari.

Talking to The Rising Nepal, Dr. Bhandari emphasised the significance of the accomplishment and attributed the success to the relentless dedication of the entire healthcare team.

"This signifies a monumental achievement for Nepal's health sector, and each member of the team deserves commendation for their tireless efforts. Following the successful liver transplant procedure, Nepali citizens will no longer need to seek the operation abroad," said Dr. Bhandari.

The liver transplant, conducted on a 41-year-old man, involved a generous donation from his 40-year-old wife. Dr. Bhandari shared that the patient is set to be discharged on February 1, marking a significant step forward in Nepal's medical landscape.

This achievement stands out as the first instance of an entirely Nepali-led liver transplant, distinguishing it from the first liver transplant in Nepal on December 17, 2016, at the Human Organ Transplantation Centre Bhaktapur. During that inaugural surgery, a team of skilled surgeons from South Korea played a pivotal role.

Despite subsequent liver transplants in Nepal, all previous procedures involved collaboration with foreign medical experts. Notably, the Teaching Hospital witnessed its first transplant on May 31, 2019, facilitated by an Indian expert team.

Despite subsequent liver transplants in Nepal, all previous procedures involved collaboration with foreign medical experts. Notably, the Teaching Hospital witnessed its first transplant on May 31, 2019, facilitated by an Indian expert team. Although ten subsequent transplants occurred at the hospital, all the transplants relied on the expertise of foreign professionals.

The recent success at Teaching Hospital underscores Nepal's growing capabilities and expertise in advanced medical procedures, marking a significant stride towards self-sufficiency in the field of organ transplantation.

HUNDREDS OF TRACTORS BRING FARMERS' PLIGHT TO AN EU SUMMIT

AP
Brussels, Feb.1

Convoys with hundreds of angry farmers driving heavy-duty tractors arrived at European Union headquarters, bent on getting their complaints about excessive costs, rules and bureaucracy heard by EU leaders at a summit Thursday.

After warming their limbs at burning piles of pallets overnight, the farmers mounted their vehicles and entered the Belgian capital with the rumble of engines, firecrackers and blaring horns piercing the early morning slumber in a culmination of weeks of protests around the bloc.

Govt submits document to UNESCO to put Tilaurakot in World Heritage List

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rupandehi, Feb. 1

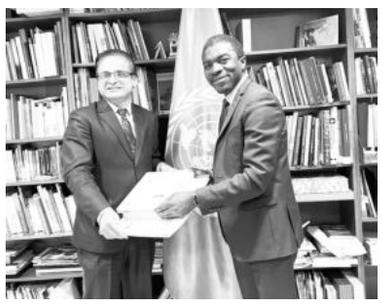


PHOTO: TRN
Sudhir Bhattarai, Ambassador of Nepal to France and Permanent Delegate of Nepal to UNESCO, officially submitting the documents to the Director of UNESCO's World Heritage Centre, Lazare Eloundou Assomo.

The government has presented the final documents related to enlisting Tilaurakot in the World Heritage List to the UNESCO World Heritage Centre.

Sudhir Bhattarai, Ambassador of Nepal to France and Permanent Delegate of Nepal to UNESCO, officially submitted the documents to the Director of UNESCO's World Heritage Centre, Lazare Eloundou Assomo on Wednesday.

Issuing a press statement on Thursday, the member secretary of the Lumbini Development Trust, Sanu Raja Shakya informed that the strategic nomination documents prepared by a team of national and international experts were submitted to the central office of the World Heritage Centre in Paris, France.

The press statement read that it would be a matter of happiness if the work done by scientists, including professors from Durham University, the Ministry of Culture, Tourism, and Civil Aviation, Lumbini Development Trust and the Department of Archaeology were accomplished.

The project to prepare adequate evidence and documents for the inclusion of Tilaurakot in the World Heritage List has been initiated since 2014 under the leadership of Professor Robin Coningham of Durham University. The project is funded by UNESCO Japanese Funds-in-Trust.

The final submission of documentation to the central office of UNESCO marks a significant step forward.

'Impacts of carbon emission on human health need to be studied'

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 1

CPN (UML) Chairperson KP Sharma Oli said all sides should be serious to the issues negatively affecting human health.

Chairperson Oli said this at an interaction 'climate change impacts on environment and resolving measures' organized by the CPN (UML)'s department of forest and environment at party office in Chyasal, Lalitpur.

Oli, also the former Prime Minister, said human interests and unawareness are negatively impacting the health and environment.

Chairperson Oli said human being should know adaptive skills to check negative impacts of climate change in human life and environment. "All sides should adopt serious efforts to resolve problems by mitigating negative effects of carbon emission on human health".

Noting the need of study on the effects of carbon emission triggered by brick industries in the Kathmandu Valley, he said the government should incentivize and promote the establishment of industries adopting technology avoiding carbon emission in the Valley.

Department head Bharati Pathak stressed the need to prevent and resolve the carbon emission which is beyond the earth's bearing capacity.

Man held for...

Senior Superintendent of Police at the Investigation Office, Somendra Singh Rathaur, informed that Tamang was found involved in defrauding millions of rupees from over 600 people. They were falsely assured of jobs in various European countries as Malta, Poland and Croatia, and Canada. Tamang assured the victims that he would send them to these countries, Rathaur added.

Tamang had worked as an agent for different human resource recruitment offices including Ayus Manpower since 2073BS and facilitated sending people to Dubai, Qatar and Malaysia. But since 2077BS, he was absconding and hiding in the country and India after a case filed on fraud and criminal gain.

Moreover, he was even running an educational consultancy at Balaju bearing a fake identity card, the police investigation stated.

Even the government employees were conned by him. Some of such employees quit the jobs. They were allured of employment in Europe.

Investigation revealed that he took Rs 1.8 million from a person for false facilitation in sending him/her to Canada, while Rs 800 thousand for Malta, Rs 700 thousand for Poland, Rs 650 thousand for Croatia.

Western...

Locals like Nabaraj Neupane observed around half a foot of snow in Jumla headquarters.

Bir Bahadur Shahi from Hima Rural Municipality said that despite January historically being the coldest month, snowfall now occurs sporadically in December, January and February.

Reporter Rajan Raut from Humla reported the first snowfall south of the district headquarters, Simikot. Settlements such as Limi, Nyalo, Hilsa, Yari, and Chala under Namkha Rural Municipality in the northern part also experienced snowfall. The Armed Police Force deployed in the area reported snow accumulation of up to about two and a half feet.

On Thursday the temperature in Kathmandu was recorded at 5.3 degrees Celsius and the lowest temperature was recorded at minus 0.5 degrees Celsius.

South Africa says Israel is already ignoring UN court ruling

AP
Pretoria, Feb.1

Israel has ignored the ruling by the U.N.'s top court last week by killing hundreds more civilians in a matter of days in Gaza, South Africa's foreign minister said Wednesday, adding that her country has asked why an arrest warrant for Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has not been issued in a case South Africa filed at the separate International Criminal Court.

Foreign Minister Naledi Pandor said South Africa would "look at proposing other measures to the global community" in a bid to stop Israel killing civilians during its war in Gaza against Hamas militants, but didn't go into details.

The preliminary ruling by the U.N.'s International Court of Justice in South Africa's case accusing Israel of genocide in Gaza ordered Israel to do all it can to prevent death, destruction and any acts of genocide against Palestinians in the territory. It stopped short of ordering a cease-fire. It also ruled Israel must urgently get basic humanitarian aid to Gaza and submit a report on steps taken to abide by the ruling within a month.

A top official in South Africa's foreign ministry has said the country hopes that Friday's ruling, and whether Israel is abiding by it, will be discussed on a wider level at the United Nations, possibly as early as Wednesday.

Since the ruling, Israel has continued its military offensive, which it says is aimed at Hamas, and hundreds more Palestinians have been killed, according to figures from the Health Ministry in Hamas-run Gaza. The ministry said Wednesday that 150 people were killed in the territory in the last 24 hours, bringing the total number of Palestinian deaths in the war to more than 26,700.

The Health Ministry's count does not differentiate between combatants and civilians. It says the majority of the dead are women and children.

"I can't be dishonest. I believe the rulings of the court have been ignored," South Africa's foreign minister said. "Hundreds of people have been killed in the last three or four days. And clearly Israel believes it has license to do as it wishes."

Pandor said there was a danger of the world doing nothing to stop the civilian casualties in Gaza and said similar inaction contributed to the horrific death toll in the genocide in Rwanda in 1994, when more than 800,000 people were slaughtered in the East African country.

"We are allowing this to happen again, right before our eyes, on our TV screens," Pandor said.

The court's ruling is binding on Israel, and the country could face U.N. sanctions if it is found to be breaching its orders, although any sanctions may be vetoed by close ally the United States.

Netanyahu has said that Israel "will continue to do what is necessary to defend our country and defend our people." Israel says the offensive is aimed at destroying Hamas after its Oct. 7 attacks on Israel that killed some 1,200 people, mostly civilians.

Israel says it has abided by international law and is doing its best to minimize civilian casualties in Gaza. It says it has killed more than 9,000 militants and accuses Hamas of embedding in civilian areas, making it difficult to avoid civilian casualties.

South Africa's governing party, the African National Congress, has long compared Israel's policies in Gaza and the West Bank to its own history under the apartheid regime of white minority rule, which restricted most Black people to "homelands" before ending in 1994.

Pandor also said South Africa was eager to pursue the case it has lodged with the separate International Criminal Court, an indication the country will continue its legal pressure on Israel. In the ICC case, South Africa accuses Netanyahu of war crimes and asks the court to order his arrest.

The ICJ and ICC are both based in The Hague but deal with different cases.

Putin vows to make military gains in Ukraine

AP
Moscow, Feb.1



President Vladimir Putin vowed Wednesday to push back Ukrainian forces to reduce the threat of attacks on Russian territory as he met with activists running his campaign ahead of the March presidential election that he's all but certain to win.

Asked about plans for the military campaign in Ukraine, Putin said the line of contact needs to be pushed back to "such a distance from our territory that will make it safe from Western-supplied long-range artillery that Ukrainian authorities use for shelling peaceful cities."

He added the Russian military has been doing just that, "pushing the enemy back from vital populated centers."

"This is the main motive for our guys who are fighting and risking their lives there -- to protect the Motherland, to protect our people," he added.

Ukraine has struck inside Russia recently, including a Dec. 30 attack on the border city of Belgorod that killed 25 people, injured over 100.

Putin also said Russian investigators concluded that Ukraine used U.S.-supplied Patriot air defense systems to shoot down a Russian military transport plane in the Belgorod region on Jan. 24. Russian authorities said the crash killed all 74 people onboard, including 65 Ukrainian POWs heading for a swap.

Ukrainian officials didn't deny the plane's downing but didn't take responsibility and called for an international investigation.

Putin said Russia wouldn't just welcome but would "insist" on an international inquiry on what he described as a "crime" by Ukraine.

Putin, 71, who is running as an independent candidate, relies on a tight control over Russia's political system that he has established during 24 years in power.

With prominent critics who could challenge him either jailed or living abroad and most independent media banned, his reelection in the March 15-17 presidential vote is all but assured.

"Russia has been forced to defend its interests, including by military means," Putin told the meeting with his campaign staff, saying that even as the meeting was going on, Russian troops made new gains on the edge of the town of Avdiivka in eastern Ukraine.

"We are passing through a very difficult and important period in the development of our country, the strengthening of its independence and sovereignty in all vectors," he said. "Scum that is always present is being washed away bit by bit."

Under a constitutional reform that he engineered, Putin is eligible to seek two more six-year terms, potentially allowing him to remain in power until 2036. He is already the longest-serving Kremlin leader since Soviet dictator Josef Stalin, who died in 1953.

Three other candidates who were nominated by parties represented in parliament are also running: Nikolai Kharitonov of the Communist Party, Leonid Slutsky of the nationalist Liberal Democratic Party and Vladislav Davankov of the New People Party.

All three parties have been largely supportive of the Kremlin's policies. Kharitonov ran against Putin in 2004, finishing a distant second.

Boris Nadezhdin, a 60-year-old local legislator in a town near Moscow, also is seeking to run. He has openly called for a halt to the conflict in Ukraine and starting a dialogue with the West.

Thousands of Russians across the country signed petitions in support of Nadezhdin's candidacy, an unusual show of opposition sympathies in the rigidly controlled political landscape that raises a challenge for the Kremlin. On Wednesday, Nadezhdin submitted 105,000 signatures to the Central Election Commission, which is expected to review them over the next few days.

'Janakpurdham should be developed by promoting Maithili language, culture'

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Janakpur, Feb. 1



Chairman of the CPN (Unified Socialist) and former Prime Minister Madhav Kumar Nepal has said that the government must invest in the development of the Maithili language and culture.

Speaking at the inaugural session of 'Literature-Art and International Drama Festival' in Janakpurdham on Thursday, leader Nepal said that the Maithili language, literature and culture are in crisis and every one should strive to protect them.

He said that there are 136 distinct castes in Nepal and everyone should maintain their unique identity.

Stating that Janakpurdham is a historical and religious place, he said that Janakpurdham should be developed as a tourist area and made a centre of attraction for Hindus.

Chairman of Janata Samajbadi Party Nepal and former Deputy Prime Minister Upendra Yadav said that the government should take responsibility for the development of all languages.

He said that Maithili is the second most spoken language in Nepal and emphasised that the government at all levels should be serious about the development of the Maithili language.

Yadav also suggested that constitutional amendments might be necessary to address existing discrimination in language development.

Lalbabu Raut, former Chief Minister of Madhes Province, said that the government under his leadership had operated the Madhes Pragya Pratishthan for the development of various languages and had provided financial support for the development of the Maithili language.

He stressed the need for the current government to continue efforts to make Maithili the official language, mentioning the preparation of a bill for this purpose during his leadership.

The five-day festival aims to facilitate in-depth discussions on politics, language, literature, art, and culture. As part of the festival, a tableau covering various aspects of Mithila was exhibited in Janakpurdham.

Travis Kelce Star of His Own Biographical Comic Book

REUTERS
New York, Feb. 1



Want to know more about Taylor Swift's boyfriend?

He will be the subject of a comic book coming out shortly.

TidalWave Comics has added 34-year-old American football star Travis Kelce to its FAME series, which features the life stories of prominent people.

The glossy, which will be released on Feb. 7, chronicles Kelce's college and NFL career, as well as his life off the field - hosting TV show "Saturday Night Live," his weekly podcast, and his philanthropy work.

Naturally, pages are also dedicated to his love story with pop sensation Swift.

The Kelce-Swift romance has been pure gold for the National Football League, spiking interest across social media and increasing merchandise sales.

TidalWave Comics recently updated its own Taylor Swift comic book, featuring the singer dressed as a cheerleader.

Kelce will compete in the Super Bowl in Las Vegas on Feb. 11, but Swift could miss it due to scheduling conflicts with her "Eras Tour," which has her performing in Tokyo on Feb. 10, the night before the Super Bowl.

Nepal America International Film Festival from June 20

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

The 7th edition of the Nepal America International Film Festival (NAIFF) is scheduled to take place from June 20 to 23 in Maryland and Washington DC, USA.

The festival, organised by the Nepal America Film Society based in Maryland, has been an annual event since 2017.

The festival will showcase a variety of films, including narratives, documentaries, short films and animations.

The organisers accentuate a special focus on independent films from diverse regions, including Nepal, America, and South Asia.

In addition to featuring international films, the festival will highlight local talent through the 'DMV Close-up,' a section dedicated to filmmakers from Washington DC, Maryland and Virginia.

Collaborating with the 'Global Peace Film Festival' in Florida, the event aims to provide a platform for entertainment and knowledge exchange for both the audience and participants.

After conducting the previous two editions online due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the upcoming festival will see a return to in-person screenings.

"We fully embraced in-person events in 2023, and we are eager and hopeful to continue offering visitors a fully in-person lineup of exhibitions and events in 2024 as well," said Yubakar Rajkarnikar, Festival Director.

NAIFF 2023, held from June 22–25 at AFI Silver Theatre and Cultural Centre, Old Greenbelt Theater, and Brentwood Arts Exchange, showcased industry panels, filmmaker conversations and in-person networking events.

Federal judge dismisses Disney's free speech lawsuit against DeSantis

AP
Orlando, Feb. 1



A federal judge on Wednesday dismissed Disney's free speech lawsuit against Florida Gov. Ron DeSantis, dealing a setback to the company's hopes of regaining control of the district that governs Walt Disney World after it was taken over by the governor's appointees.

U.S. District Judge Allen Winsor in Tallahassee said in his decision that Disney lacked standing in its First Amendment lawsuit against the Republican governor and the secretary of the Florida Department of Economic Opportunity. The judge also said Disney's claim against DeSantis' appointees to the Disney World governing district lacked merit.

Disney said it plans to appeal the federal judge's decision. A separate lawsuit over who controls the district is still pending in state court in Orlando.

Disney had argued that legislation signed by DeSantis and passed by the Republican-controlled Legislature that transferred control of the Disney World governing district from Disney supporters to DeSantis appointees was in retaliation for the company publicly opposing the state's "Don't Say Gay" law. The 2022 law banned classroom lessons on sexual orientation and gender identity in early grades and was championed by DeSantis, who had used Disney as a punching bag in speeches on the campaign trail until he recently suspended his campaign for the 2024 GOP presidential nomination.

Disney supporters had run the district, which provides municipal services such as firefighting, planning and mosquito control, for more than five decades after the Legislature created it in 1967.

Winsor, who was appointed to the bench by President Donald Trump in 2019, said in his decision that Disney didn't have standing to sue the governor because DeSantis already had picked the appointees to the board of the governing district.

"Because Disney seeks injunctive relief, it must allege an imminent future injury ... and it has not alleged facts showing that any imminent future appointments will contribute to its harm," the judge wrote.

In dismissing the claim against the DeSantis appointees to the district's board, Winsor wrote that when a law on its face is constitutional, plaintiffs can't make free-speech claims challenging it because they believe lawmakers acted with unconstitutional motives. The law that revamped Disney World's district didn't single out Disney by name but rather special districts created before the ratification of the Florida Constitution, a group that included the Disney district and a handful of other districts, he said.

"Here, similarly, no one reading the text of the challenged laws would suppose them directed against Disney," the judge wrote. "The laws do not mention Disney."

The DeSantis-appointed chairman of the revamped district, Martin Garcia, called the lawsuit a distraction. He said now that it is behind them, board members can focus on making appropriate changes to the district's operations "to promote transparency and accountability while bringing more prosperity to more people in Florida."

Disney said the case was too important for it to end, with serious implications for the rule of law.

"If left unchallenged, this would set a dangerous precedent and give license to states to weaponize their official powers to punish the expression of political viewpoints they disagree with," Disney said in a statement.

The governor's press secretary, Jeremy Redfern, said the judge's decision supported DeSantis' belief that Disney doesn't have a right to its "own special government."

"The days of Disney controlling its own government and being placed above the law are long gone," Redfern said.

DISSIDENT RUSSIAN ROCK BAND IN ISRAEL AFTER DEPORTATION FROM THAILAND

AP
Israel, Feb. 1

A dissident Russian rock band angered by Moscow's war in Ukraine has arrived in Israel after being deported from Thailand under suspected pressure from the Kremlin, the performers said Thursday.

The seven members of the band Bi-2 were arrested last week after playing a concert on the southern resort island of Phuket, reportedly for not having proper working papers. On Facebook, they said all their concerts "are held in accordance with local laws and practices." Phuket is a popular destination for Russian expats and tourists. After paying a fine, the band members were sent to an immigration detention center in Bangkok.

Speaking in the arrival hall of Israel's Ben Gurion International Airport in Tel Aviv, guitarist and singer Aleksandr "Shura" Uman of Bi-2 said the band was doing well and very tired after their ordeal. He also called the conditions he and his band faced in a Thai jail as "horrible."

"We are free and we will keep moving forward," Uman said.

Uman thanked the Israeli, American and Australian diplomats, as well as human rights organizations, for their work to bring them to Israel. A handful of supporters met their early-morning flight with signs to welcome them to Israel.

Russia has denied it had a hand in trying to get the band deported. However, Moscow has a reputation for cracking down on artists critical of the war, even those working abroad. The Kremlin had previously singled out Uman and another member of Bi-2, Yegor "Lyova" Bortnik.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Telling the world about a plan you've been chewing on in secret might be necessary today. Although your audience will likely be happy to see your genuine excitement.

TAURUS: Your friends might currently be making noises about wanting to do something exciting but short on actual ideas. Fortunately, as clever Mercury in your 9th House of Adventure supports fuzzy Neptune in your social zone.

GEMINI: Being vague about your goals could frustrate you now. Remember: you don't have to solve this problem alone. While thoughtful Mercury in your collaboration sector reins in spacey Neptune in your ambitious 10th house.

CANCER: A penetrating conversation could push you to pin down your beliefs today. You might be afraid that committing to a specific position will result in at least some of your peers judging you harshly.

LEO: A bureaucratic matter might seem intimidating at the moment. You can make progress eventually if you keep chipping away at it bit by bit. That said, knowing what you can't do all by yourself could also be key to finding a solution.

VIRGO: Your desire for a transcendent experience could be interfering with your recent relationships. You're not likely to succeed in getting to know someone better if you're too caught up in idealizing them.

LIBRA: Defining your responsibilities at home more clearly may now be necessary. Although you're probably willing to pitch in and do your fair share, something possibly seems to be getting.

SCORPIO: Telling a dramatic story about yourself can help you connect with others at present. As articulate Mercury in your communication zone aligns with artistic Neptune in your expressive 5th house.

SAGITTARIUS: Taking action on a favorite interior decorating fantasy of yours is possible today. While calculating Mercury in your 2nd House of Resources harmonizes with sentimental Neptune in your domestic zone.

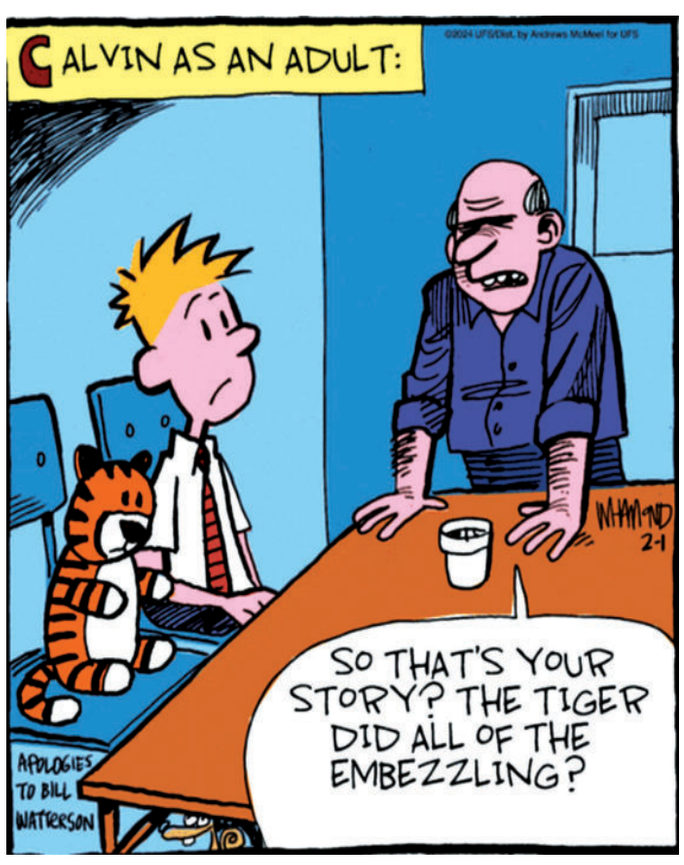
CAPRICORN: You're equipped to communicate something that really matters to you today. While verbal Mercury in your sign supports visionary Neptune in your conversation zone.

AQUARIUS: Playing it vague regarding a recent money matter could protect you. While fact-finding Mercury in your secretive 12th house bolsters shifty Neptune in your finance zone.

PISCES: Going along with what your friends want to do could be rewarding today. Although you might worry that you're developing a reputation for being too passive.

CARTOON

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Army confirms title showdown with Police at PM Cup

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1



Tribhuwan Army Club has entered the finals of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament-2024 for the sixth consecutive season defeating Gandaki Province on the final day of the group-stage matches on Thursday.

With 14 points from seven wins in nine matches, Army stands two points clear of 3rd and 4th positioned Bagmati and Madhes respectively.

Army qualified in the finals of the Men's PM Cup five earlier editions in 2017, 2018, 2019, 2021 and 2022, and lifted the trophy in 2021 defeating APF Club.

In the first edition in 2017, Army and Nepal Police Club were announced as joint winners after the match was affected due to rain. Army lost the trophy to APF twice, in 2018 and 2022, and to Police in 2019.

Alike the past five editions, departmental teams continued their dominance as two of the three clubs progressed to the finals in the sixth edition as well. Second-positioned Army will face table-topper Police at TU International Cricket Ground on Saturday for the sixth edition's trophy.

Winning its final league-stage match against Sudur Pashchim Province at Mulpani International Cricket Ground on Thursday, Police stands at the top of the table with 18 points as 'undefeated'.

Meanwhile, Army did not get an easy win. Electing to bat first, Army was bundled out for a paltry 132 in 39.1 overs with opener Imran Sheikh as the highest scorer (34 off 64). While Sompal Kami added 23 off 39, captain Binod Bhandari, Bhim Sarki and Kushal Malla only contributed 19, 10 and 15 runs respectively.

Sandeep Rajali and Basir Ahamad departed for a duck while Bibek Yadav (1 off 7) and Santosh Karki (2 off 15) at least opened their accounts. Bipin Khatri, Amrit Gurung, Krishna Poudel and Kamal Pariyar bagged two wickets each while Sandeep Parajuli and Roshan Gautam bagged one each for Gandaki.

Nevertheless, Gandaki's batting faced more devastation than the Army's as they chased a low target. Opener Ishwar Chhetri (16 off 27) and Karan Pangeni (15 off 28) were the only batsmen for Gandaki to score in double figures before the team lost its ninth wicket in the 24th over for 64 runs. Kamal Pariyar remained absent hurt leading the officials to declare Army as the winner.

Shahab Alam took four wickets, Kushal Malla and Jitendra Mukhiya bagged two each, while Sompal Kami did not bag any.

7 wickets for Dipendra

Electing to bat first, Nepal Police Club did not have a good start against Sudur Pashchim as it lost its openers – Dilip Nath (6 off 19) and Kushal Bhurtel (5 off 7) – by the first powerplay.

However, the middle order sustained the team. Shankar Rana (46 off 52) and captain Dipendra Singh Airee (44 off 38) could not reach the 50-run mark while Arjun Saud and Aarif Sheikh added 32 and 26 runs respectively.

Sher Malla was Sudur's highest wicket-taker with three; Narayan Joshi, Bikash Aagri and Milan Bohora bagged two each while Dipak Chand took one.

While Sudur Pashchim looked forward to ending Police's unbeaten run, Airee clearly said 'no' sending seven batsmen, including the top five, back to the pavilion single-handedly.

Airee showcased the best bowling figures in the edition so far with his 7-wicket haul in 10 overs, including four maidens, and giving only 20 runs. While there have been seven six-wicket hauls and 13 five-wicket hauls in this edition, it is the first seven-for.

Sagar Dhakal, Lalit Bhandari and Lalit Rajbanshi took the remaining three wickets for Police as Sudur Pashchim got bundled out at 120 in 37.1 overs.

Gajendra Bohora was Sudur's highest scorer followed by 24 off 18 and 24 off 38 from the bats of Kiran Thagunna and Naren Saud respectively.

Bashir set for England debut, Anderson back

AP
Visakhapatnam, Feb. 1



England will debut 20-year-old spinner Shoaib Bashir against India in the second test starting Friday, barely a week after he was stranded at home without a visa to come on the tour.

Bashir, a British Muslim of Pakistani heritage, was the only member of England's touring party to be significantly delayed over his visa application. That drew comment from Prime Minister Rishi Sunak's office that it expects British citizens to be treated fairly by India.

Bashir was grounded following a training camp in Abu Dhabi while his teammates transferred to Hyderabad ahead of the first test, which was won in extraordinary fashion by England on Sunday. He had to return to London and eventually received approval, arriving in India last weekend. He is in the team as a replacement for Jack Leach, who has been ruled out because of injury.

England captain Ben Stokes brushed aside concerns that Bashir's preparations for the tour have been affected, saying Thursday: "There's no issues for me that he's been away from the group for a period of time, then come back in to make his debut. It's not like he's forgotten how to bowl."

Bashir has taken just 10 first-class wickets in six games at an average of 67, while Leach's absence means England's three specialist spinners have three caps between them — two for Rehan Ahmed and one for Tom Hartley.

At the other end of the age spectrum, 41-year-old seam bowler James Anderson — England's record wicket-taker — also came into the side for the match in Visakhapatnam, replacing Mark Wood.

Anderson will be the only pacer in the team as he sets out on his 22nd calendar year of international cricket, and the first since the retirement of long-time fellow fast bowler Stuart Broad.

"It's huge credit to him and lots of people should look up to Jimmy considering he is where he is at 41," Stokes said. "Bringing in Jimmy's experience, and the class that he has, is great for us and I think it also goes under the radar how good his record in India is.

"Considering what Jimmy is known for — the swing king and all that — it just proves how good a bowler he is. Taking nothing away from Woody, we just feel like there's a bit more I can turn to him for."

Already missing star batter Virat Kohli because of personal reasons, India said on Monday the team would be without allrounder Ravindra Jadeja (hamstring) and batter KL Rahul (quadriceps) due to injuries sustained in the first test.

THREE STAR FACING ARMY FOR 23RD AAHA RARA GOLD CUP

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 1

Tribhuwan Army Club has secured its place in the finals of the 23rd Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup against Three Star Club on February 3. Army defeated A-Division league champions Church Boys United 2-1 in the second semi-final match of the tournament on Thursday. Three Star defeated Jawalakhel Youth Club in the first semi-final match on Wednesday.

Army was able to extend its lead and win the match in the extra time as the 90 minutes ended 1-1. While the first half ended goalless, Army scored the first goal of the match in the 63rd minute as Dinesh Henjan scored on a freekick. Church Boys equalised the score as Samir Tamang scored in the 87th minute and led the game to extra time.

Rash B. Magar scored the winning goal for Army in the 103rd minute as he headed a cross to the back of the net. Army had chances to extend the lead further while Church Boys missed many chances to equalise and take a lead. Army will have a hard time in the finals as Three Star Club, which has won the Aaha! Rara Gold Cup five times, is not an easy opponent to beat.

IRAN MEETS JAPAN IN QUARTERFINAL

AP
Doha, Feb. 1

Iran booked its place in the Asian Cup quarterfinals by beating Syria on penalties after the game ended 1-1 through extra time. It plays Japan at Education City Stadium on Wednesday. Three-time champion Iran needed a penalty shootout to beat Syria, one of the tournament's surprise packages.

Down to 10-men after Mehdi Taremi was sent off in time added on, Iran eventually won 5-3 on spot kicks at Abdullah bin Khalifa Stadium. The game had ended 1-1 through extra time. Taremi fired Iran ahead with a penalty in the 34th after he had been fouled by Aiham Ousou.

Syria then equalized from the spot through Omar Khrbin in the 64th after Pablo Sabbag was brought down by Iran keeper Alireza Beiranvand. Syria was playing in the knockout stage of the Asian Cup for the first time and was given an advantage when Taremi was sent off in the first minute of stoppage time for a second bookable offense. But it could not make the most of the extra man and the game remained level through extra time.

Gagan Tharu constructs playground in Baijanath

BY GOVINDA SHARMA
Banke, Feb. 1



Gagan Tharu, a local of Baijanath Rural Municipality in Banke district, has constructed a playground in Ward No. 4's Bikashnagar at personal expense.

According to Tharu, he converted the land he rented at Rs. 50,000 per year for agricultural purpose into a playground as there was a shortage for children and youths in the area.

Areas have been allocated for football and futsal alongside other sports, such as badminton and taekwondo, in a bigha of land.

"Around 150 children and youths come daily for training. We plan to develop the current playground into a training centre," said Tharu.

The land has been leased to Tharu for 10 years. Tharu informed that around Rs. 700,000 has been spent to erect necessary infrastructures to date.

"A proper playground was one of the major needs in the locality and I bent towards the demands of youths. While the playground can be used for free now, we plan to employ experienced trainers of different sports and charge a certain fee shortly," said Tharu.

The initiative of Tharu might also receive support from the provincial government, informed Ratna Kharti, a member of the Lumbini Provincial Assembly.

"If a general citizen is investing to produce quality athletes for the country, the state should support it. The provincial government has been made aware of Tharu's activities," said Khatri.

Liverpool and City flash deep squads in big wins

AP
Liverpool, Feb. 1



Liverpool and Manchester City look primed and ready for another heavyweight clash for the Premier League title.

Liverpool routed Chelsea 4-1 on Wednesday to restore a five-point lead for Jürgen Klopp's team atop the table before going to third-placed Arsenal this weekend.

City eased to a 3-1 win over Burnley and moved up again to second, ahead of Arsenal on goal difference, and having played a game fewer than its two rivals.

With their fourth straight wins, the Premier League powers showcased deep squads, fast-improving young stars and, for City, the tentative return of feared forward Erling Haaland after nearly two months out injured.

Haaland came off the bench with City comfortably in a three-goal lead as Julián Álvarez again stepped up to lead the attack with two goals. The second was created by Kevin De Bruyne making his first start in the Premier League since August.

For Liverpool, Diogo Jota again covered for the absence of Mohamed Salah and opened the scoring early against a poor Chelsea taking a pass from the impressive Conor Bradley.

Bradley, an unheralded 20-year-old right-back filling in for Trent Alexander-Arnold, then scored his first goal for the club before assisting again for Dominik Szoboszlai to effectively seal the win in the 65th.

Liverpool had the luxury of forward Darwin Núñez missing a first-half penalty, one of a Premier League record four times one player struck the frame of the goal in a game.

Man City edged Liverpool in epic duels for the title in 2019 and 2022, and north London rivals Arsenal and Tottenham are also currently in this race.

Tottenham scored three goals in eight second-half minutes to beat Brentford 3-2 and rise to fourth, trailing Liverpool by eight points. Tottenham cannot be counted out just yet. Whatever Premier League road that coach Ange Postecoglou's team takes, it should be one of the most watchable on its journey.

After a poor first half at home to Brentford, Tottenham burst into a 3-1 lead within 11 minutes of the second half.

Destiny Udogie leveled in the 48th, one minute before Brennan Johnson scored the go-ahead goal. Richarlison scored what proved the decisive goal in the 56th.

Ivan Toney cut the lead scoring for the second straight game since his return from an eight-month ban for betting violations.

A testy edge was created by Brentford forward Neal Maupay appearing to mock the dart-throwing goal celebration favored by Tottenham playmaker James Maddison after scoring in the first half.

Barcelona edges Osasuna

With coach Xavi Hernández still in charge, Barcelona got back on track with a 1-0 win over Osasuna in the Spanish league on Wednesday.

Young Brazil forward Vitor Roque scored his first goal since joining the club in Barcelona's first match since Xavi announced he will leave at the end of the season.

The victory moved Barcelona back within eight points of Spanish league leader Girona. Barcelona sits seven points behind Madrid, which can retake the lead if it wins at Getafe on Thursday in its postponed game because of the Super Cup. Atletico Madrid stayed in third place, just ahead of Barcelona, after a 2-1 win over Rayo Vallecano, with Memphis Depay scoring a 90th-minute winner at the Metropolitano stadium.

It was the fifth goal in five matches for Depay, who had a goal disallowed for offside in the 82nd. Reinildo had given the hosts the lead in the 35th with his first goal with Atletico, and Rayo equalized with Álvaro García in the 42nd.

The victory extended Atletico's unbeaten run at home to 28 matches in all competitions. Its last home defeat was against Barcelona in January last year in the Spanish league.

WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:50 am, Sunset at 5:45 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly to generally cloudy in Koshi Province along with the hilly regions of the country and mainly fair in rest of the country. Light rain is likely to occur at one or two places of hilly region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province. Chances of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and at one or two places of high hilly and mountainous regions of rest of the Provinces.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	13.6	10.8	23.2
Dadeldhura	4.5	3.5	23.8
Dhangadi	15.4	13.2	14.2
Birendranagar	12.9	11.5	7.3
Nepalgunj	16.6	13.0	1.0
Jumla	3.6	-0.5	0.5
Ghorahi	16.6	11.0	Traces
Pokhara	17.6	9.8	Traces
Bhairahawa	21.6	9.0	0.4
Simara	23.9	8.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.8	5.3	Traces
Okhaldhunga	15.2	5.5	7.3
Taplejung	14.6	3.8	0.0
Dhankuta	20.7	7.0	0.0
Biratnagar	24.8	10.0	0.0
Jomsom	5.1	-3.1	0.0*
Dharan	24.5	13.0	0.0*
Lumle	11.0	5.4	0.0*
Janakpur	25.8	10.0	0.0*
Jiri	12.7	0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 2, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.45	Rs. 133.05
Euro	1	Rs. 143.10	Rs. 143.75
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.31	Rs. 168.07
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.44	Rs. 154.14
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.27	Rs. 86.66
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.39	Rs. 98.84
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.75	Rs. 99.20
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.02	Rs. 9.06
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.44	Rs. 18.52
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.32	Rs. 35.48
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.33	Rs. 36.50
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.73	Rs. 3.75
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.06	Rs. 36.22
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.00	Rs. 28.13
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.93	Rs. 9.97
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.64	Rs. 12.70
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.20	Rs. 19.28
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.94	Rs. 17.01
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.56	Rs. 432.51
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.33	Rs. 352.92

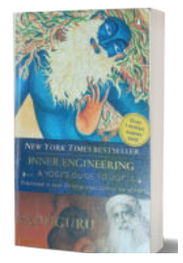
Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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THE RISING NEPAL
Friday
SUPPLEMENT
Friday, February 2, 2024
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Glowing Moon, Luminous Night | B



Sadhguru's Blueprint For Bliss | C

Experiencing Japan's Tradition And Innovation Up-close



Manjima Dhakal

I recently had an opportunity to visit Japan for a week through the JENESYS programme hosted by the Japan International Cooperation Centre (JICE). Before embarking on my journey, my curiosity about this advanced Asian nation was high. Japan, known for maintaining its development despite facing frequent disasters like earthquakes and tsunamis, heightened my interest. Additionally, I was keen to understand the growing appeal of Japan as an educational destination for Nepali students. With these curiosities and a sense of excitement, I commenced my trip to Japan, a nation celebrated for its unique blend of tradition and innovation, in mid-December.



Toilet marvel

My memorable experience in Japan started with a surprising encounter with their high-tech toilet. The country's commitment to innovative technology and dedication to cleanliness left a lasting impression on me. Upon arriving at Narita International Airport in Tokyo, I took a moment to freshen up in the restroom. The high-tech Japanese toilets there provided me with a delightful experience. Features such as heated seats, automatic water spray, warm water availability, and a built-in dryer showcased a high level of innovation. Beyond the technological advancement, the most noteworthy aspect of my experience was the cleanliness of public toilets in Japan. This standard of hygiene was not confined to airports but was consistently maintained across diverse settings, including hotels, restaurants, homestays, shopping malls, and railway stations. The fancy toilets I found everywhere in Japan showed how much they wanted everyone to have access to this cool technology. While using these technologically advanced toilets, a desire was sparked within me for the adoption of such innovative restroom technology in own country. Considering that the country is currently transitioning from open defecation to closed toilets, I couldn't help thinking about the feasibility of implementing such advanced technology. The wish for these advancements was made without recalling the current state of the country's sanitation infrastructure.

> Visiting Japan can be tricky, as not many people speak English, even in public places like malls. The language barrier can make it hard to ask even simple questions. Our group had a tough time and wasted about two hours because we couldn't use Google Maps on the street as we could not connect to the internet.

Punctual and disciplined

I noticed that Japanese were always on time and well-disciplined, leaving a strong impression on me. I met Japanese officials, who were punctual and organised. Throughout my visit, the disciplined behaviour of the citizens continued to influence my experience positively. The punctuality and orderliness I observed became defining aspects of my time in Japan. The organised waiting stations outside the airport and the subsequent comprehensive briefing about the programme underscored the Japanese commitment to punctuality and clarity. Clear instructions regarding the rules of our stay further strengthened the notion that punctuality and discipline are integral cultural values. From the beginning of activities to the ongoing proceedings, the officials ensured that each participant was well-informed and aware of the significance of being on time. The entire programme was started only in the presence of all participants, and there was an expectation for everyone to follow the schedule. The evidence of commitment to punctuality was the timely departure and arrival of trains and buses or an on-time programme.

One striking example of Japanese discipline is the strict adherence to seat belt usage. Japanese citizens not only wear seat belts themselves but also remind others to buckle up promptly. People throw their trash in the right bins and avoid littering, showing their dedication to a clean and orderly environment. This careful approach to garbage disposal highlights Japan's commitment to keeping its surroundings pristine. It's a testament to their strong emphasis on cleanliness and orderliness. Japan, despite having an ageing population, impressed me with the industriousness of its people. During our homestay, we witnessed the dedication of an elderly Japanese couple who not only managed their accommodation but efficiently handled logistics for a group, maintaining flawless hygiene standards. This exemplifies Japan's commitment to punctuality, discipline, and a robust work ethic, traits that persist even in the elderly population.





Technological advancements

Japan is a nation frequently grappling with natural disasters such as earthquakes, tsunamis, and typhoons. The nation's proactive approach to disaster management, which involves advanced technology, early warning systems, and community education, has been minimising the human and economic toll of calamities. In Tokyo, the capital city, towering skyscrapers reaching up to the 50th floor showcased Japan's impressive engineering and commitment to earthquake resilience. Meanwhile, in the village of Nagano, traditional wooden houses also demonstrated strong resilience. Coming from a country that has experienced substantial human and material losses due to inadequate structural systems, I was impressed by Japan's technological advancements in creating structures that effectively withstand earthquakes.

The iconic Shinkansen, or bullet train, exemplifies Japan's technological prowess. With speeds reaching over 200 miles per hour, these trains are not just a mode of transportation but a symbol of efficiency and precision, even in mountainous areas. From the revolutionary Shinkansen and earthquake-resistant buildings to cutting-edge technological developments, Japan stands at the forefront of progress. The integration of technology is easily adjusted into daily life, as seen in the advanced toilet systems.

Preservation of culture

Japan takes pride in preserving its rich cultural heritage. Government initiatives play a crucial role in this regard. The participants were taken to a Nagano village for homestay. During my stay with a family in Japan, I loved how they followed their unique traditions. They were really kind and welcoming. The mix of their culture and their warm hospitality made my stay memorable. One distinctive aspect was the traditional Japanese sleeping arrangement, where a bed (futon) was offered on the floor.

One of the culinary highlights during my time in Japan was the variety of Japanese cuisine presented artistically. From traditional sushi to sashimi, each dish was crafted with precision and creativity. The use of fresh, high-quality ingredients was apparent. It was evident that the art of food presentation is deeply ingrained in Japanese food culture. The immersion into Japanese culture continued with engaging lessons on origami, a traditional art form of paper folding. During my time in Japan, they offered kimono, a traditional Japanese garment that carries profound cultural significance and is often worn on special occasions or celebrations. A unique cultural experience was the visit to a public bath, an integral part of Japanese daily life. The emphasis on communal bathing not only highlighted hygiene practices but also underlined the importance of shared spaces in fostering community bonds. The unique aspect was the absence of garments and bathing naked, a practice rooted in tradition during communal baths. Similarly, exploration of local museums further enriched my understanding of Japan's history. The vivid illustrations and artefacts provided insights into the nation's past, offering a glimpse into the cultural evolution and milestones that have shaped contemporary Japan.



Beyond cultural exploration, the host family's efforts to teach their language added a personal touch to the homestay experience. These efforts not only safeguard Japan's cultural identity but also provide an immersive experience for both locals and visitors. For these, the contribution of the Japanese government is very high.

Language barrier

Visiting Japan can be tricky, as not many people speak English, even in public places like malls. The language barrier can make it hard to ask even simple questions. Our group had a tough time and wasted about two hours because we couldn't use Google Maps on the street as we could not connect to the internet. We think Japan should find a way to make it easier for visitors, so they don't face these problems. Even though there's a language barrier and some difficulties, exploring a new culture feels like an exciting adventure. We hope Japan can make things better for international visitors by coming up with appropriate solutions. Despite the challenges, we still enjoyed discovering and learning about the new culture.

Nepali diaspora

The presence of Nepali people in Japan is particularly noticeable, with many actively involved in the restaurant business. Despite having a personal interest in connecting with them, their work schedule often hindered the opportunity for direct interactions with them. It is found that most restaurants, particularly those labelled as serving Indian foods, are operated by the Nepali community. I came across restaurants called Tara Kitchen, Asian Dining Lumbini, Indian Restaurant Tulasi during my visit.

Bhawan Bhatta, former president of NRNA (Non-Resident Nepali Association), said approximately 3,700 restaurants in Japan are operated by Nepalese. This development is seen as a source of economic prosperity for Nepalese living in Japan. Most of the restaurant workers are also Nepalese students. The business helps Nepalese in their economic growth.

Shraban Satyal, Tara Kitchen operator in Tokyo, said Nepalese are able to establish own business only after a long struggle there. He further said that Nepalese on student visas are find it challenging in Japan due to financial pressures from their families. Satyal advised parents not to have immediate expectations from their children studying in Japan. He pointed out that those who are willing to work hard and put in effort can still make progress in Japan.

I also met a Nepali in Tokyo who transitioned from a student visa to a work visa. Despite the higher income ratio in Japan compared to Nepal, she shared that the journey came with huge sacrifices. Currently employed at a Japanese hotel where accommodation is provided on the premises, she mentioned the challenges of being unable to access Nepali food for months, adjusting to Japanese cuisine for a long time as one of the toughest aspects of her experience. This sheds light on the complexities individuals face when pursuing opportunities abroad, underscoring the importance of adaptability in such situations.

Despite all challenges, the growing attraction of Japan to Nepali students is because it combines educational aspirations with the promise of prosperous career paths. Based on my observations, attractive job opportunities and growth in Japan have enticed Nepali students.

Japan-Nepal connectivity

Japan's expertise in various sectors can benefit less developed countries, addressing challenges and improving infrastructure. Nepal, with its mountainous terrain, could learn from Japan's bullet train system to enhance transportation. High-speed rail networks could efficiently connect cities and reduce travel times. Japan's success in waste management, particularly recycling and waste-to-energy initiatives, can be shared with SAARC countries like Nepal, where effective waste management ideas are sought.

Japan has been introducing many projects since the 2015 earthquakes in Nepal, which is appreciable. Even now, there can be collaboration in designing and implementing earthquake-resilient structures in Nepal. This can enhance preparedness and minimise the impact of disasters. Likewise, Japan can initiate educational programmes and workshops to share its technological knowledge and expertise with professionals and experts in the concerned area. As Japan has made advancements even in hydropower technology, it can collaborate with Nepal to develop efficient and sustainable hydroelectric projects. Establishing collaborative research projects between Japanese and SAARC institutions can facilitate the development of innovative solutions tailored to the specific needs of the region. Japan has been contributing to Nepal; it can be a better way if both sides contribute to this.

The journey to Japan exposed me to an interesting blend of tradition and modernity. Factors such as cleanliness, innovation, and punctuality, which are embodied in Japanese culture, left a deep impression on my mind. The progressive toilet technology, which symbolised the Japanese innovation pursuit, inspired a wish to emulate such innovations in my homeland. Collaboration and shared knowledge between Nepal and Japan can ensure further development as Japan continues to provide support for Nepal. This experience highlighted the importance of multicultural studies, showing how they can bring about positive changes.

It demonstrated how one nation's blend of tradition and technology can influence processes, fostering better relations between people from different countries. Overall, it underscored the diverse ways multicultural studies can contribute to global understanding and collaboration.

(The author is a journalist at The Rising Nepal .)

Glowing Moon, Luminous Night



Dr. Rishi Shah

> Full moon would be called a snow moon because the heaviest snow would fall during this time of the year.

The nippy night skies of this month would pleasantly please planet-lovers with sights of planets Jupiter and Saturn, along with Uranus and Neptune. Tiny terrestrial planets such as Mercury and Venus could be admirably applauded, but not in confounding constellations with strange stars. Planets Mercury and Mars will stay mostly unseen this month. Mercury would be moving through the constellations Sagittarius (archer), Capricornus (sea goat), and Aquarius (water bearer) during the day. Mars would be marching mainly across Capricornus. They would hover low at dawn in the eastern sky. Planet Venus would be visible shortly in the southeastern sky before sunrise.

It would be venturing valiantly across the northern sector of the constellation Sagittarius. On February 22, planets Venus and Mars would make a close approach (conjunction) to one another. Adulating this enigmatic event in Capricornus would be challenging for us during the daytime. A waxing gibbous moon would be 98 per cent luminous at night. The mighty giant planet Jupiter, with its mesmerising Jovian moons, could be adorned as a lucent spot in the southwestern sky at dusk in the southern section of the barren-alike expanse of the compact constellation Aries (ram). It would be hastening towards the horizon later at night. The ringed planet Saturn could be glimpsed succinctly above the western horizon after sundown during the month's beginning. It would be skylarking with the scintillating stars of the constellation Aquarius. It would be lost gradually in the sun's glare by the end of the month.

Dim stars like Sadalmelek, Sadalsuud, Sadachbia, Ancha, Skat, and Albali would be glistening in its neighborhood. The yellow supergiant stars Sadalsuud and Sadalmelik would be sprinting through space perpendicular to the plane of our galaxy, the Milky Way. Sadalsuud would be almost 56 million years old and roughly 540 light-years away. Sadalmelik would be solely 6.5 times as massive as the Sun and merely 520 light-years away.





NIGHT SKY IN FEBRUARY 2024

The main sequence star Sadachbia would be substantially 2.5 times the Sun's mass and double the solar radius. It would be perhaps 164 light-years away. Ancha's mass would be virtually three times that of the Sun, and its radius is practically twelve times that of the Sun. Skat would manifest the double of the solar mass. Ancha would be decently 187 light-years away, but Skat is appreciably 113 light-years away. The white-hued star Albali would be nominally 208 light-years away. Peculiar planetary helix nebula NGC 7293 could be astounded with amazement in Aquarius. It was identified by German astronomer Karl Ludwig Harding in probably 1824.

It would be 655 light-years away from us. The greenish planet Uranus would be noticeable in the southwestern sky after sunset. It would be sinking towards the horizon by midnight. It could be discerned to the east of Jupiter in the constellation Aries. The far-flung blue planet Neptune would be perceivable after nightfall in the western sky. It would be sliding towards the horizon until the wee hours of the night. It would be cavorting beneath the stars of the charismatic circlet asterism of the V-shaped constellation Pisces (fish).

The current February would entail 29 days, as 2024 would be defined as a leap year. The new moon would befall on February 9, while the full moon would enthral moon-enthusiasts on February 24.The full moon would be called a snow moon because the heaviest snow would fall during this time of the year.

Since hunting would be difficult during the harsh weather, this moon would also be known as the hunger moon. Venerated Sri Saraswoti Puja would be celebrated respectfully on February 14 on Valentine's Day.

Our blue planet Earth would require approximately 365.25 days to orbit the Sun once to complete one solar year, which would be conventionally rounded up to 365 days in one calendar year.

A day would be the amount of time it would take the earth to concoct one rotation on its axis. If leap years were not interspersed, all those missing hours would add up to days, weeks, and even months. Consequently, in a few hundred years, a warm summer month, for example, July, would actually occur in the cold winter months. To make up for the leftover piece of partial day, one day would be added to our calendar circa every four years. Furthermore, the calendar year would be comfortably synchronised with the astronomical year and with the seasons. That particular fourth year, in simple terms, would be tagged as the leap year.

Astronomical affairs and seasons do not repeat for a whole number of days. Calendars that have a constant count of days annually would unavoidably drift over time with respect to the seasonal festivals that would have to be culturally observed. By inserting (intercalating) an additional day (leap day), the shift between the dating methodology of civilization and the physical properties of the solar system could be corrected. An astronomical year would linger scantly less than 365 and one-fourth days.

The legendary Julian calendar was introduced by Roman general ruler Julius Caesar in 45 BC and would indicate three common years of 365 days, followed by the leap year of 366 days until today by extending February to 29 days. However, as proposed by Pope Gregory XIII in 1582, the Gregorian calendar, the world's most widely used civil calendar, would advocate further adjustments for the error in the Julian algorithm. The extra leap day would be modified each year to be a multiple of four (except for years evenly divisible by 100 but not queerly by 400).

After a nail-biting twenty-minute descent,

ASTRONOMY

Japanese space agency JAXA's Smart Lander for Investigating the Moon (SLIM) touched down on a designated domain and established communication with the control station on earth by dispatching essential data. Although Japan became historically the fifth nation after the USA, Russia, China, and India to achieve spectacular soft landing feats, its Moon Sniper spacecraft, nicknamed for its precision technology, was running out of power due to a serious arcane solar battery problem.

SLIM is one of numerous new lunar missions that have been launched by countries and private firms, fairly fifty years after the first human set foot on the moon. JAXA would analyse data that would determine whether the craft had accomplished the goal of disembarking within one hundred metres of its intended target patch on the rim of the shrouded Shioli crater.

SLIM was aiming for a cryptic crater where the moon's mantle, the usually deep inner layer beneath its crust, was believed to have been exposed on the surface. Two small Lunar Excursion Vehicles (LEV-1 and 2) have been detached from the SLIM mothership. One would be carrying a sophisticated transmitter, and the other, a mini robot hopper, which would be slightly bigger than a tennis ball, has been designed to trundle around the lunar topology for gathering information, snapping images, and beaming them back to earth.

SLIM, as a primarily tech demonstrator, would be performing science experiments, which would be expected to last for one lunar day (barely two earth weeks). SLIM has not been equipped with heaters to protect its electronics against the frigid lunar nights. It could reveal insights on the lunar area's composition, which in turn could shed light on the moon's formation and evolution. SLIM would weigh just 200 kilogrammes without propellant.

Its cost would be less than 120 million US dollars. Crash landings, missives and message failures, and other technical quandaries have been generally rife during space explorations. Now exclusively five space-faring nations have successfully alighted on the moon.

Last month, US firm Astrobotic's Peregrine lunar Lander had been leaking fuel after takeoff, thus dooming its operation. Contact with the spaceship was lost over the remote region of the South Pacific after it had burned up in the earth's atmosphere on its return. NASA has now postponed plans for crewed lunar missions under its Artemis program.

Two previous Japanese lunar undertakings, one public and one private, had failed. In 2022, it sent a lunar probe named Omotenashi as part of the US Artemis-1 assignment. In April, Japanese startup Ispace tried in vain to become the first private company to dismount on the moon, losing touch with its craft after what was described as deplorable hard landing. An Israeli nonprofit company's Beresheet robotic explorer sadly crashed into the moon in 2019.

(Dr. Shah is an academician at NAST and patron of NASO.)

Reflection On Communication Barriers



Pushpa Priya



> Communication barriers are the problems that arise at every stage of the communication process and have the potential to create misunderstanding and confusion.

The term `communication` carries a wide range of implications in our daily lives. Communication plays a life-sustaining role in fulfilling our purpose of sending and receiving information or a message. Effective communication solves daily life problems with solutions. According to Loise E. Boone, communication barriers are the problems that arise at every stage of the communication process and have the potential to create misunderstanding and confusion.

How to overcome this problem is a significant question that revolves around the minds of people in every field. The requisite of effective communication is felt at every place, from home to school or college to working places. Effective command of this skill helps to get rid of any disputable situation and helps in maintaining an easy and comfortable life. Before stepping into any organisation, the first thing that is evaluated is communication skills. The ability to recognise communication issues and come to a resolution can drastically improve relationship bonds, working relations at the workplace, and organisational culture. There are many reasons why interpersonal communications may fail. There are many barriers to communication, and these may occur at any stage in the communication process.

Different factors causing communication barriers are: physical barriers, psychological barriers, attitudinal barriers, physiological barriers, semantic barriers, and poor communication skills. The barrier that already exists in the environment is a physical barrier. A physical barrier is an externally driven barrier. The factors that come under physical barriers are: noise, time, distance, defects in the medium, and physical barriers to non-verbal communication. For instance, when two people want to communicate and the receiver is in a hurry and does not have time to listen, it acts as a barrier. This same problem may occur when you geographically separate departments and the functions of an organization. Quick face-to-face communication becomes difficult due to the increased distance.

The telephone may not provide the answer. The line may be busy when the call is placed, or the person being called may be out of the office. Similarly, defects in the medium also act as a barrier to effective communication. For example, if A is communicating with B over a telephone line and there is a disturbance in the telephone, the receiver (B) cannot get the exact or intended message of the sender (A). Moreover, noise, other distractions, and an unpleasant environment also pose an external physical barrier to effective communication.

One of the major communication barriers is psychological. It is internally driven and associated with mental illness. In other words, it relates to the emotions, sentiments, and moods of the sender and receiver. The psychological state of the sender will determine how the message is sent, received, and perceived. Here, strong emotions like anger, arrogance (ego), over-happyness, fear, anxiety, sadness, nervousness, etc. block the communication process. Being extremely nervous about your personal agenda or certain way of winning arguments can make communication less effective. Such inner-fear emotion is also known as emotional noise, which is one of the major barriers in the communication process.

The same message can be interpreted in different ways when you are sad, angry, excitedly happy, or in a calm state. In a psychological barrier, there is an imbalanced emotional state, distrust, premature evaluation (immediately jumping to conclusions), and a lack of attention. Anger is one example of a psychological barrier to communication. When we are angry, it is easier to say things that we may later regret and also to misinterpret what others are saying. People with low self-esteem and sadness may be less assertive and therefore not feel comfortable because they consistently go through emotional imbalance inside and out. They feel shy, fear or embarrassed about how they really feel, or read unintended negative sub-texts in messages they hear.

Similarly, stress is also one of the psychological communication barriers. Stress can preoccupy someone with personal problems, hindering their ability to communicate appropriately. Expectations and prejudices lead to false assumptions or stereotyping. People often hear what they expect to hear rather than what is actually said or meant and jump to incorrect conclusions.

Likewise, attitudinal behaviour is also one of the communication barriers that hinders the communication process. Attitudinal barriers are behaviours or perceptions that prevent people from communicating effectively. It may result from personality conflicts, poor management, resistance to change, or a lack of motivation. Most often, personality conflicts occur due to differences in status relationships. The feeling of superiority and inferiority hinders the whole communication process. Lack of a motivational environment also hinders effective communication.

The next barrier to effective communication is a personal barrier. It consists of a prejudgmental attitude, perceptual obstacles, information overload, look distraction, etc. The good and bad looks of a person easily distract some people, causing them to focus on appearance and forget the intended message to be transmitted.

Moreover, semantic barriers related to language and linguistic ability may act as a barrier to effective communication. The receiver may face a barrier to understanding a message if they do not fully grasp the terminology, even when both parties share the same language.

Poor communication skills are hindrances to an effective communication process. Lack of skills in writing and speaking creates defective encoding of the messages. This damages the objective of communication. Poor listening and poor reading are the shortcomings of effective communication.

One should know how to overcome communication barriers. First of all, it is important to know the general or specific purpose of any conversation. Once it is found, it is easy to enter into a conversation. Is it to be social? Make an impression, be polite, etc.

To better communicate, we must try to see ourselves through the eyes of others in the communication link. By developing some empathy with the people to whom we will be directing messages, we might recognise the need to modify our messages from time to time before sending them.

(The author is a lecturer of English at various colleges in Kathmandu.)

Jagadish Nepali's Micro-Stories



Rameshwar Baral

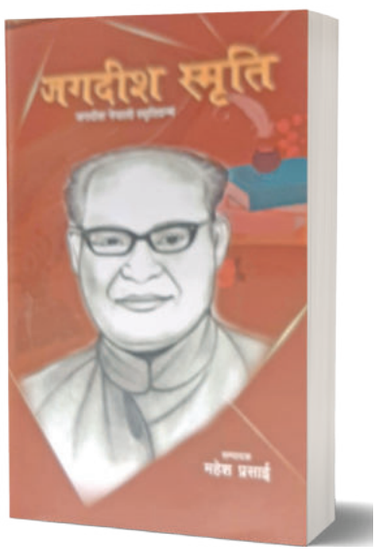
Sita Sapkota recently published 'Jagadish Smriti,' a compilation featuring 30 micro-short stories by Jagadish Nepali. The editor, Mahesh Prasai, exhibits a clear passion for this literary genre. The volume spans 406 pages, offering insightful perspectives on micro-stories and providing an extensive background on the writer. Contemporary peers of the writer have contributed reviews and illustrations, alongside critics from the post-writer years. The volume is divided into two main sections. The initial, larger section spans 370 pages and includes 63 articles about the writer. These articles shed light on the writer's profile and hint at the future significance of micro-stories. Subsequently, the volume presents the 30 stories that effectively illuminate and archive the writer's literary persona.

Micro-stories are not common in Nepali literature, with only a handful of writers exploring this genre. Interested Nepali readers, instead, tend to engage in the hobby of reading conventional genres such as fiction (both short and long), subjective essays, poetry (epic or short), and plays. 'Jagadish Smriti,' in contrast, successfully carves out micro-stories as a distinctive literary identity. It's no surprise that this genre is gradually gaining academic interest and acknowledgment. Even before the book's publication, university students studying literature were dedicating dissertation papers to these micro-stories, often earning a perfect score of 100. This trend underscores the book's significance for university colleges and Nepalis abroad (NRNs). Consequently, micro-stories are no longer considered a unique and unconventional form. However, the local book market may not experience significant returns, mainly due to a less prevalent buying culture.

> The efforts of Madhupark and individual writers contribute to the evolution of micro-writing in the Nepali landscape.

Editing and publishing

Mahesh Prasai's meticulous editing signals his extra efforts. He must have made special requests to engage learned writers for the review articles. Getting articles from them potentially must have been his prolonged and tireless waiting, not of months but of years. Sita Sapkota's publishing zeal shows that she is equally dedicated. Both the editor and publisher have close family ties too. They are cousins: Mahesh is the son of the writer's younger sister, Dharani, and Sita is the wife of the writer's younger son. The editor had spent his early days until college with the writer and his family. In that sense, the writer and his family seem to have had a clear literary impact on him. The publisher and editor have one more identity to be unveiled. The writer is the son of Mahanand Sapkota, a renowned linguistic and literary giant in Nepal. The publisher, Sita, was married into this family after her father-in-law's death. Thus, her enthusiasm to bring forth the book demands true recognition. The editor and publisher are remotely connected at present. If Sita stays far away in Texas, the editor's cousin Mahesh is in Kathmandu. Their being away across seven seas seems another reason to bring them much closer. In all, 'Jagadish Smriti' is a homage to their guardian angel



and an archive of literary contributions. Their endeavours are a sign to reawaken the writer's talent. Now the book stands as a historical testament to Nepali literature, particularly in the micro-story genre.

Global trend

Micro-stories are catchy for today's jet-set globetrotters. Time chasers can easily go through these stories in 2–3 minutes. Its specialty is brevity, which leaves a long-lasting impression. A couple of minutes in it speaks enough of a social phenomenon, a life, or an individual of unnoticed sublime value. Micro-stories, as such, are condensed capsules brimming with an underlying message. Workaholics can thus easily spare time for such mini-vitamin foils.

Contents of a story in English read in less than an hour are short novels termed micro- or flash fiction. Wikipedia defines 100-word-long fiction as drabble, microfiction, or twitterature. In this context, it is logical to appreciate that the Sanskrit folk stories of Panchtantra are micro-stories with morals and motivations. Micro-stories in this context are brief readings that take just a couple of minutes. As time in this IT-driven world relentlessly chases, such story clips play an immense role in everyday life. Consequently, life has to skip both time and reading and, unfortunately, information treasure and recreation.

If we consider examples of English and Hindi micro-stories, we find that they are already established genres. Such concise writing shares similarities with the Japanese haiku. Nepali writers were relatively few in this domain for their readers. However, they are now catching up with broader international practices. As a result, Nepali literature is making strides in embracing this condensed form. Madhupark, the Nepali monthly magazine, includes such stories in its roster between its pages. One notable example is the anthology of micro-stories, 'Phool ko Aatank,' by Dhruva Chandra Gautam. The efforts of Madhupark and individual writers contribute to the evolution of micro-writing in the Nepali landscape. In this context, micro-stories by Jagadish Nepali undoubtedly play a pioneering role in establishing the narrative prowess of a storyteller. In a world where time is limited but timeless, he has undeniably earned a prominent place.

The writer

Initially a school teacher, the writer later became known as Jagadish Sir. Educating children was his passion. Once, he invited a woman teacher, Chandra Kala Kiran, to Dharan for a home science program. She later served in the government and retired as a secretary.

He had entrepreneurial zeal, too. Once, he set up a bus transportation company under his leadership, connecting Biratnagar, Kathmandu, and Dharan. Soon, it had come to grand success. Then he proudly exclaimed, 'The company hit like a triple of three aces in the playing card game of flush!' Besides, working for others was another venture. He made frequent trips to Kathmandu and Indian regions to buy Hindi feature movies. In addition to his dignity, he was wonderful at speaking fluent Hindi, Bengali, and English. His high school education was not complete, though.

Beyond those pursuits, Jagadish had remarkable boldness in politics. In the heyday of King Mahendra, he delivered a speech in the yards of Marwari Sewa Samiti, Kathmandu. He had then sharply criticised both the alleged pretended Panchayat philosophy and the king. His challenge was against the rule, then boldly stating, 'Panchayat is not a philosophy and can never be it; it's merely King Mahendra's whim of direct rule.' Whether in his hometown or the capital city, he was an elite figure, personally known by many ministers and VIPs.

With all this, his schedules were hectic in the growing city of Dharan, which was for his growth as well as that of his family and living standards. Upon knowing this, the question is: he had time constraints, hadn't he? Truly amazing! He hasn't found time to write yet! Still, he stole free moments for the writing.

Exploring further

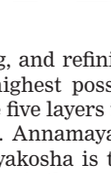
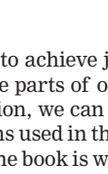
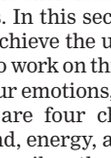
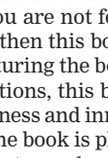
The present-day marketed book comprises 30 stories by the author. But the question is: didn't he write anymore? If he did, were they lost? I have here two more-story versions, as told by him, that I could not see in the book. Story One: Two policemen on evening duty aimed to arrest unruly drinkers to please their seniors. Upon finding no such scene in a local pub, they, hopelessly, ended up drinking themselves, had a brawl between them, and arrested a third person there as a scapegoat for their boss. Story Two: An army pensioner submitted his ID card to the office to draw his pension. Then he stood and waited in the queue.

The wait was prolonged, and he lost his temper. Now, gritting his teeth against the officer, he said, 'Why late? Should I break your tooth?' The calm officer said, 'Let's see who's to break...'. The next time the pensioner showed his ID, he had to break his own front tooth because the card mentioned, '"One tooth broken.' Whether these stories were created on short notice or were already written and subsequently lost remains unclear. Nonetheless, these anecdotes offer a glimpse into the writer's storytelling prowess and present intriguing narratives that may have slipped through the sands of time.

FUTURE WATCH

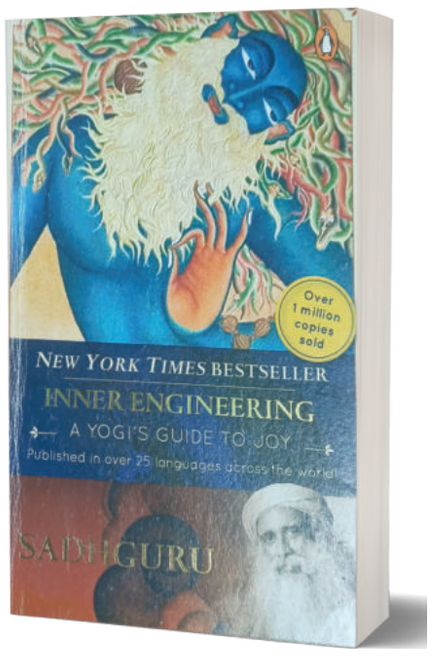
(Based on birth names)

February 2nd to 8th 2024 - D. N. Lohani

 ARIES — Initial period will keep you busy and provide some return. You may have to tackle challenges from Sunday. Students will have to work harder. Trade and profession both will turn profitable. Friend's support will provide great relief.	 TAURUS — First half is better. Major tasks will complete successfully. Uncertainty can arise within self. Despite expenses study can slow down. Health disorder is predicted. Blood pressure related issues can arise.
GEMINI — Major tasks will advance ahead at cost of extra expenses. High level of enthusiasm will guide you ahead. Lack of diplomatic ability can create some problem. Profession will yield impressive return.	 CANCER — Health disorder can increase expenses. Travel is in store for you. Business will yield limited return. Friends will provide limited support. Study will gradually take progressive course.
LEO — Incomplete assignments from past will complete successfully. High level of confidence will guide you ahead. You will win legal issue. You may have to handle new business venture. Avoid risky venture on Monday.	VIRGO — Work will complete after causing extra expenses. Students will have to work harder. Writing skill will improve. You will succeed in creating new article. Trade and profession both will turn profitable.
LIBRA — Pleasant event can occur on today and tomorrow. You will enjoy good company of interesting ones. Study related travel can occur. Friends will provide appreciable support.	SCORPIO — You may have to treat others at own expenses. You will enjoy pleasant meeting with interesting ones. High level of enthusiasm will guide you ahead. You may have to handle new obligation. Hardship will guide you ahead. Relatives will cooperate.
 SAGITTARIUS — Prevailing fear and confusion can reside within self. Regular gain will help in consolidating your financial position. New friends can join your circle. You will retain progress in technical sector. Pleasant event can occur during weekend.	 CAPRICORN — You will experience busy schedule. Income will be lower than expectation. Opponents will remain active. Employees will have to overcome obstacles. Success without struggle is unlikely. Students will have to work harder. Business can slow down.
 AQUARIUS — Expenditure level will rise. With some effort, important assignments will complete successfully. foreign trade will prosper. Decisive ability will guide you ahead. Others will be satisfied with your oratory ability.	 PISCES — You may have to handle new obligation. Circumstances will improve from Tuesday. Decisive ability will guide you ahead. You may create new article. Health disorder is predicted. Trade and profession both will turn profitable.

BOOK REVIEW

Sadhguru's Blueprint For Bliss





Samjhana Aryal

Sadguru is a yogi, mystic, and visionary whose work has touched the lives of millions worldwide. His approach does not ascribe to any belief system but offers methods for self-transformation that are both proven and powerful. Sadhguru's Inner Engineering, a yogi's guide to joy, relies on the teachings and principles of classical yoga to help readers create an enduring foundation for inner stability and peace. The book shows you a straightforward way to feel really good through the traditional science of yoga. It explains things in a practical and easy-to-understand way, with lots of funny and interesting stories. The book contains life-changing quotes and illustrates sadhanas in a very simple, precise way.

The book is divided into two sections. The first maps the terrain, and the second offers us a way to navigate it. The book opens with an interesting short story about Shankaran Pillai, a pharmacist who gave him a box of laxatives for a whooping cough. The writer then presents an insightful description of the four-letter word 'Guru' that literally means 'dispeller of darkness'. The writer considers self-transformation as a dimensional shift in the way we perceive and experience life. The one who embodies this is a yogi, and the one who guides you in this direction is a guru.

The first chapter, 'When I Lost My Sense,' describes how Sadguru developed as a highly curious and observant person and how he became a student of Malladihalli Swami. He describes his daily routine when he was a schoolboy and shares how he began to understand that what the sacred traditions and scriptures had extolled as the ultimate experience was happening to him. The second chapter, 'The way out is in' discusses how we have allowed our thoughts and emotions to come from outside rather than inside. He expresses that we ourselves are the greatest source of technology, but the problem is that we don't know where the keyboard is. Sadguru encourages us to do right things by saying that unless we do right things, the right things will not happen to us.

The third chapter, 'Design your destiny', portrays how we define and shape destiny. Sadguru says that whatever we do not want to take responsibility for, whatever we cannot make sense of logically, we label destiny. Therefore, he explains that when pain, misery, or anger happens, it is time to look within us, not around us. The fourth chapter, 'No boundary, no burden', discusses that responsibility simply means our ability to respond. He says our ability to respond is limitless, but our ability to act is limited. Sadguru talks about'stress management' that he heard widely in the U.S. He explains how we manage the things that are precious to us. So why should we manage stress?

The fifth chapter of the first section is 'And now Yoga'. In the beginning, the writer explains yoga as the technology of upgrading, activating, and refining these inner energies for the highest possibilities. Then he talks about the five layers to which yoga draws our attention. Annamayakosha is the food body; manomayakosha is the mental body; pranamayakosha is the energy body; vignanamayakosha is extraordinary knowledge; and anandamayakoshya is bliss beyond the physical. Towards the end of this chapter, he says that to experience wellbeing, all we need is a certain mastery over these dimensions of body, mind, and energy.

The second section of the book provides a more specific and deeper exploration of the three fundamental layers: body, mind, and energy. Moreover, this section oscillates between information, suggested practice, and self-observation exercises. To implement each of the exercises, "Sadhana" is offered in the boxes. In this section, we learn that if we want to achieve the ultimate goal of our lives, we have to work on three important things that control our emotions, thoughts, and lives.

There are four chapters in this section: body, mind, energy, and joy. The first chapter, 'Body', describes the yogic physiology of the body, the yogic approach to physical health, the importance of asanas (postures), and the yogic approach to food. The second chapter, 'Mind', describes the yogic psychology of the mind (intellect, emotion, and identity) and the importance of awareness. The chapter 'Energy' describes the yogic energy physiology of a human being and the yogic approach to the mechanics of life. The last chapter, 'Joy', makes us move to experience joy as one's own nature. Therefore, body, mind, and energy are the three essential things for humankind, and to achieve joy, we have to maintain these three parts of our existence. After the second section, we can find a glossary of the difficult terms used in the book.

The book is well organised and well written, with clear explanations and practical stories. This book can be taken as a roadmap for positive education that helps students be well, flourish, and live a happy, engaged, meaningful, and accomplished life. Lifecrafting techniques such as reflecting on values and best selves, writing about an ideal future and plans, and setting and attaining goals presented in this book assist young people's search for meaning and purpose in life.

The 'Inner Engineering' methodology preserves classical Hatha Yoga and the multi-dimensionality of classical yoga. The book covers the concept of connecting to our soul. If you are not feeling peace and happiness in life, then this book can be helpful. Thus, from nurturing the body to nurturing the mind and emotions, this book helps to cultivate holistic wellness and inner harmony.

The book is pleasant, motivating, and applicable to awaken our own intelligence, deepen our perception, and bring about a dimensional shift in the way we look at our lives, work, and the world. This book offers invaluable insights rooted in extensive research and enriched by valuable practical experience. Its content provides a roadmap that can be followed to enhance the overall well-being and happiness of human beings. In addition, this book offers valuable insights and practical wisdom on how to effectively navigate and harmonise our physical, mental, emotional, and fundamental life energy aspects.

Learning Cross-cultural Appreciation



Kaushal Pant

Today's interconnected world is considered a global village, and as a consequence of cosmopolitan development, people are turning into global citizens. "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" is a Sanskrit phrase that translates to "The world is one family." Rapid development of the technology has made the Sanskrit phrase clearer.

To turn the world into a global village and encourage people to be global citizens, education and awareness are crucial. Education is a powerful tool because it knows no boundaries. The Indian Embassy in Nepal is actively organising different educational and cultural exchange programmes for students of various age groups to promote learning and understanding. The Swami Vivekananda Cultural Centre (SVCC) at the Indian Embassy in Nepal is dedicated to improving students' creative abilities through a unique approach.

The SVCC Embassy of India recently organised a learning programme for students, focusing on ancient and traditional learning models and employing fun and interactive methods. The camp received great enthusiasm and love from the participating students. The programme aimed to blend historical approaches with enjoyable learning experiences. The positive response from the students highlighted the success of this educational initiative.

According to the Director of SVCC, Dr. Asawara Bapat, the programme facilitated the students not only to learn academics but also provided a proper insight into intercultural and cultural differences. Over time, this comprehension fosters a sense of mutual respect within the minds and souls of students. Simultaneously, the academic programme expands their thinking, encouraging innovation and creativity. The Fun and Learns programme is dedicated to nurturing students in a homely environment, breaking free from the constraints of a daily course book. It seeks to create a space where students are not confined or limited in their learning.





This holistic approach aims to instill a profound understanding of mutual respect and foster a spirit of innovation and creativity. The programme envisions students developing a broader mindset and embracing a more open and unrestricted approach to education. The programme is conducted by experts, so it is believed that these activities can be a stepping stone for the students to explore their hidden talent, as each and every child is born with a unique talent.

Dr. Bapat mentioned that the Embassy has been offering scholarships for Nepali students in academic and career-focused education in India. Additionally, over the past two years, the local-level activities of SVCC have gained popularity among secondary school students. These activities are becoming increasingly well-received in the community.

Such an approach involves introducing school students to the fascinating realms of Vedic mathematics and Brahmi Lipi during a uniquely crafted Fun and Learn Personality Development Camp.

Integral to the camp is the fusion of education with entertainment. Through interactive camp, students are engaged in team-building activities, creative exercises, traditional fun games, and yoga. The camp was really a playground for personality development, where students learned to communicate effectively, collaborate with peers, and think critically.

Vedic mathematics

Vedic mathematics is an ancient system originating from India that promises to revolutionise the way students perceive and solve mathematical problems. Contrary to conventional methods, Vedic mathematics sutras simplify complex mathematical problems.

Through interactive games, puzzles, and real-life applications, students explore the speed and efficiency that Vedic mathematics offers. This approach enhances students' skills to encourage creative problem-solving and critical thinking.

Brahmi Lipi

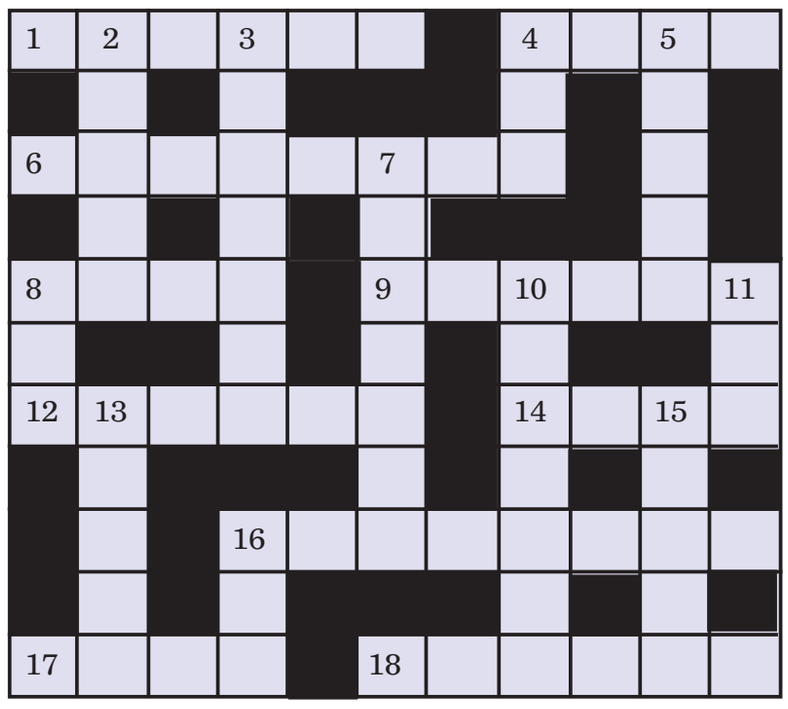
As students immerse themselves in the intellectual playground of Vedic mathematics, they embark on a linguistic adventure exploring Brahmi Lipi. This ancient script, which dates back to the 4th century, forms the basis of many modern Indian scripts and has played an essential role in preserving historical inscriptions and manuscripts.

This method not only enhances students understanding of linguistic evolution but also promotes cross-cultural appreciation.

In conclusion, the Fun and Learn Personality Development Camp served as a bridge between ancient wisdom and modern education. Through Vedic mathematics, Brahmi Lipi, and personality development activities, the camp created a dynamic learning environment where students not only acquired knowledge but also developed skills that will serve them well throughout their academic and personal journeys. It also enriches students' understanding of the historical and cultural context of the Indian subcontinent and contributes to the broader fields of linguistics and cultural studies.

(The author is a freelance writer.)

TRN CROSSWORD PUZZLE NO. 1776



Name .....

Address .....

Signature .....

Last date of entry:
February 7, 2024

Win a prize of Rs. 600. In case there are more than one correct entry the prize will be split into three sums of Rs. 200 each. The winner will be selected by a lucky draw. Only cuttings (not photo copy) that include the Crossword Puzzle no. will be accepted.

Across
1. Social position
4. A formal treaty
6. Show mercy
8. Lunch is one
9. Easily done
12. Keep watch over an area
14. Add fuel to
16. Dismiss the parliament
17. Work out
18. An area of activity, interest

Down
2. Fine silk for veils
3. Performs somersaults
4. Suffer the consequence
5. Make unnecessary objection
7. Lies comfortably against
8. A person's face
10. Extremely large
11. The last point
13. Very bad
15. On no occasion
16. Put on clothing item

Solutions to TRN Crossword Puzzle No. 1775

ACROSS: 1. HASSLE 4. FRAY 6. ASSUAGED 8. A TIE 9. TOPPLE 12. IMPEDE 14. EXAM 16. LASHINGS 17. DRUG 18. STEALS

DOWN: 2. ASSET 3. SQUEEZE 4. FAD 5. AVAIL 7. GUTLESS 8. AMI 10. PRECISE 11. ELM 13. MAJOR 15. ANGEL 16. LOG

LUCKY WINNER

Sunil Sharma Bhattarai
Damodar Lohani
Bal Krishna Shrestha

ALL CORRECT ANSWER

Archana Devi Shrestha, Kumari Nirmala Giri, Khagendra Nath, Mahendra Kumari Nath

CREATIVE CORNER

Woman



Saanvi Dhakal

Restless and sleepless eyes
Waiting for their loved ones to come
Tired of everything but has a smile
Has the courage to face everything
For loved ones
Sometimes being tortured, threatened
But is loyal to the one
World criticizes to her but faces it strongly
World wouldn't be a better place
Without her
But still after these hard work
She is the one to be blamed
But still has a smile on her face



Class: IX
S.T Marys High School



Shlok Upadhyay, Grade: III, Rai School

TRN PUZZLE NUMBER-408

All you have to do is to fill up in the seven boxes below with the numbers in such a way that the sum will be 364 whether you go diagonally, horizontally or vertically. The numbers should be 28 to 76 between. The number should not be used twice.

	66		28		46	
	74			45	54	
		35	44		62	
		43	52		63	
40			60			31
48	50		68	70		39
					38	47

88	97	106	59	68	77	86
96	105	65	67	76	85	87
104	64	66	75	84	93	95
63	72	74	83	92	94	103
71	73	82	91	100	102	62
79	81	90	99	101	61	70
80	89	98	107	60	69	78

TRN PUZZLE SOLUTION-407

Prepared by: Bishwo Nath Kharel

Childhood Memories



Saloni Karki

When I was a child, electricity was not available 24 hours a day. It followed a specific schedule, allowing us access for only three to four hours each day. This restriction left me with a lot of free time, without any particular interests or leisure activities to occupy myself with. My sister and I used to watch television together whenever electricity was available. Otherwise, I would be out with my small group of friends playing our favourite games like chungi, bouncing, or hide and seek.

One summer vacation, my father bought me a bicycle after a lot of requests. It was a bit bigger compared to how small I was. I used to go cycling with my friends frequently. We specifically cycled down the inclined road near the old-fashioned home of our town. The area was filled with greenery. While the intense heat would take away all the energy from our bodies, the cool breeze always made us feel rejuvenated. Sleeping on the moist grass and looking at the birds fly through the dancing trees; we'd level up our spirits after every race. The small shops nearby sold all sorts of candies and snacks, but our favourite was the ice lollies we had sitting on the lawn for a refreshment.

There was a drunkard who passed by that road often. Whenever he came towards us, we would run away as far as possible. He didn't really have a good reputation among the children. Parents themselves used his example to scare their kids whenever they threw tantrums. In our group of three—two girls and a boy—we pedalled our bicycles swiftly, each of us aiming not to be the last, as being closer to the drunkard than the others was something none of us desired.

After cycling together for months, we took on a challenge. All three of us decided to ride a bicycle. Pinky had the biggest bicycle of all, so we chose to ride on that one. I was in charge of the handle while sitting at the top of the tube. Pinky had to paddle while sitting on the saddle. The little guy's job was to simply sit in the back seat. Since his height was below average, we called him a little guy. We rode down the inclined plane like this once every two or three days. As the air went past our faces, our hair flew behind us, and our clothes pulled our bodies apart. We'd laugh to our hearts' content. Every day felt like a new adventure doing so. The thrill made our hearts beat so fast that our smile never went away throughout the whole experience. I believe Armstrong felt the same stepping on the moon as we felt riding down the road every time.

One day, while doing the same, I encouraged Pinky to paddle faster than usual. Throughout the whole ride, I kept on pressuring her to paddle faster. She did as she was told. We were enjoying the ride so much that we lost our balance. At the end of the road, we all fell towards the bush. Both Pinky and I got injured. Still, the pain of the fall was overshadowed by how amazing the ride was. We were all laughing while our knees bled. Pinky mocked me, saying I asked for the fall myself as I forced her to paddle quicker. On the other hand, the little guy didn't have even a single scratch on his body. He had cleverly gotten out of the bicycle before it could crash. While both Pinky and I had leaves over our hair and bodies, he was unharmed. Although the accident wasn't his fault, we scolded him badly for being able to escape alone, leaving us behind to become casualties.

This memory lives in my head. It will forever stay with me, and I will always have a special place for it in my heart. With the increase in use of mobile and other technologies, do you think the newer generation will have a chance to live such moments? Will they have stories to talk about? Or will their lives be impacted only by the use of the internet? I hope even the "ipad kids" get to know what it feels like to play around and have the company of good people, since companionship is the main way human beings are able to shape themselves into better people.

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Aadarsha Poudel, Grade: VI, Liverpool School